

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · June 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	76.8
#2	A+	Atlanta	73.4
#3	A+	Kansas City	70.7
#4	A+	Charlotte	68.6
#5	A	Nashville	67.3
#6	A	Austin	65.0
#7	A	Hartford	63.7

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Jacksonville	22.2
#49	C-	Richmond	29.5
#48	C-	Minneapolis	30.4
#47	C-	Louisville	30.8
#46	C-	Riverside	30.9
#45	C	Sacramento	34.1
#44	C	Grand Rapids	34.4

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	22 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · June 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	76.8	3.0%	+4.1%	+2.0%	+0.9%	46 days
2	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A+	73.4	2.8%	+5.2%	+0.2%	+0.9%	50 days
3	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	70.7	3.3%	+8.0%	-0.0%	+0.2%	43 days
4	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	68.6	3.5%	+2.1%	+1.1%	+0.2%	47 days
5	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	67.3	3.0%	+5.8%	+0.3%	+0.0%	52 days
6	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	65.0	3.4%	+6.8%	+0.6%	+0.5%	56 days
7	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	63.7	2.7%	+1.5%	+1.9%	+2.8%	25 days
8	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A	63.2	3.1%	+4.2%	+0.3%	-1.1%	36 days
9	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A-	62.6	3.5%	+6.3%	-0.4%	+1.4%	45 days
10	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A-	62.6	3.6%	+4.3%	+1.3%	-1.1%	45 days
11	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	58.8	5.1%	+5.6%	+2.0%	+0.9%	51 days
12	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	58.4	3.8%	+2.4%	+0.5%	+0.4%	48 days
13	Birmingham Birmingham	B+	56.0	2.4%	-1.2%	+0.7%	-1.0%	54 days
14	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B	54.5	4.1%	+6.8%	+0.6%	-1.5%	39 days
15	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	54.2	5.1%	+7.4%	+0.1%	-1.2%	36 days
16	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	54.1	3.9%	+6.7%	+0.3%	-2.4%	32 days
17	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	53.6	4.7%	+6.9%	+0.1%	+0.0%	67 days
18	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	53.5	3.9%	-0.4%	+0.1%	+1.0%	36 days
19	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	52.8	3.7%	0.0%	+1.3%	-1.2%	29 days
20	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B	52.4	4.2%	+5.7%	+0.4%	N/A	42 days
21	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	51.9	4.3%	+1.9%	+0.2%	-0.1%	49 days
22	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	51.4	N/A	+4.8%	+1.8%	-1.6%	47 days
23	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B	50.8	4.5%	+2.8%	+1.1%	+1.1%	70 days
24	Columbus Columbus	B-	49.5	2.8%	+3.3%	+0.2%	-1.4%	33 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	48.8	3.4%	-0.6%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
26	Memphis Memphis	B-	48.8	4.1%	+6.2%	-0.1%	-0.9%	58 days
27	St. Louis St. Louis	B-	48.1	3.6%	+1.8%	-0.5%	+0.0%	42 days
28	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	46.8	3.5%	+0.7%	-0.2%	-2.2%	43 days
29	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	46.4	3.9%	+7.3%	-0.2%	+0.3%	79 days
30	Fresno Fresno	B-	46.2	8.1%	+4.2%	+1.7%	-0.2%	52 days
31	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	B-	46.0	3.5%	+6.8%	-0.7%	-1.1%	33 days
32	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	45.3	3.8%	+3.3%	+0.6%	-2.5%	60 days
33	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	43.7	4.3%	+3.5%	+0.6%	+1.7%	30 days
34	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C+	41.3	4.9%	+4.3%	+0.1%	-2.6%	33 days
35	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	41.3	2.6%	+0.5%	-0.7%	-0.8%	42 days
36	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	39.4	3.8%	+1.6%	+0.0%	+0.1%	57 days
37	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	39.1	4.3%	+4.9%	-0.7%	+0.0%	33 days
38	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	C	37.0	3.6%	+6.2%	-1.0%	-3.0%	49 days
39	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C	36.7	3.9%	+3.7%	-0.4%	+2.9%	25 days
40	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	36.2	3.7%	+1.5%	-0.9%	-0.6%	32 days
41	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C	35.7	3.9%	+4.8%	-2.9%	-2.5%	30 days
42	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C	35.6	4.4%	+2.3%	-0.9%	-0.1%	38 days
43	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.4	4.8%	+6.2%	-2.9%	-1.6%	47 days
44	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C	34.4	3.6%	+3.0%	-0.1%	-7.0%	30 days
45	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	34.1	4.5%	+1.1%	+0.4%	-1.7%	41 days
46	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C-	30.9	4.9%	+5.4%	+0.0%	-2.2%	56 days
47	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	30.8	4.0%	+2.3%	-0.8%	-1.4%	38 days
48	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C-	30.4	3.8%	+0.5%	-0.4%	-0.9%	34 days
49	Richmond Richmond	C-	29.5	3.4%	+3.0%	-0.5%	-0.9%	36 days
50	Jacksonville Jacksonville	D	22.2	4.8%	+1.2%	-0.4%	-0.5%	59 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

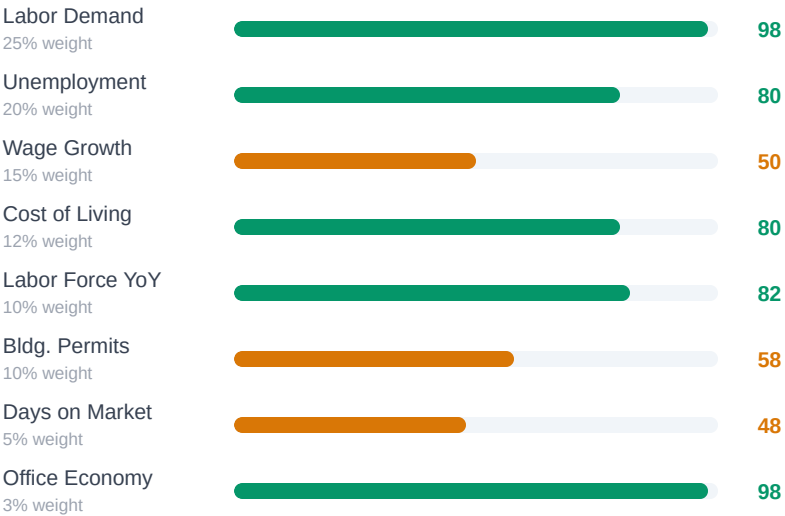
A+

EXCELLENT

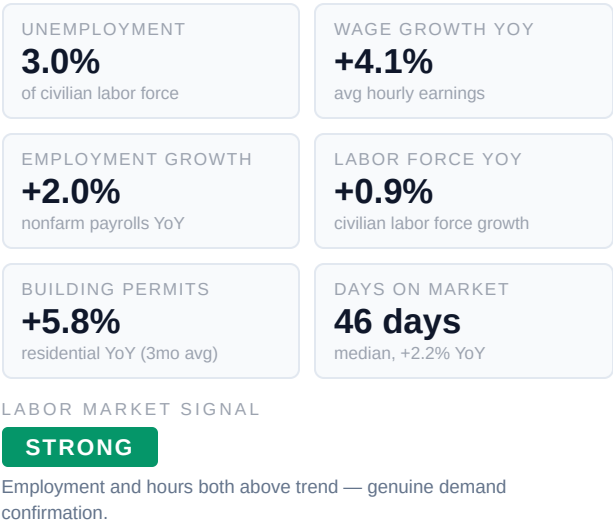
76.8th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 76.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 98th percentile, driven by a 2.02% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.762% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. The combination of strong employment growth and above-trend hours signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area is experiencing a significant expansion in labor demand, with a 2.02% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.762% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs at a rapid pace and workers are putting in more hours than usual. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 is in the top tier, ranking in the 98th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.00%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 80th. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Raleigh-Cary is 4.09%, which is near the median, ranking in the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. While this may not be ideal for employers looking to keep costs low, it is beneficial for workers who see their earnings increase over time.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score that ranks in the 80th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The city's price-to-salary ratio is \$220/sqft divided by \$38.03/hr, which equals 5.78, and the fact that PSF is falling by 1.4% year-over-year makes it even more attractive. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive salaries without needing large wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a year-over-year rate of 0.90%, which ranks in the 82nd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees to hire from.

This is a favorable condition for companies looking to scale their operations or expand into new markets.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 5.85% year-over-year, ranking in the 58th percentile. This moderate growth in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the pace of growth is not exceptionally high, which may not fully keep up with demand in the short term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is currently 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.2%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market that is still competitive but showing signs of normalization. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market remains somewhat accessible, although it may require prompt decision-making to secure a desired property.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 98th percentile. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge workers. On the other hand, it may be less ideal for companies primarily involved in industrial or logistics operations that do not rely as heavily on professional and office-based talent.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, moderate wage growth, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for wage pressure and competition for talent in a relatively tight labor market, which could impact hiring and operational costs over time.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A+

EXCELLENT

73.4th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		72
25% weight		
Unemployment		88
20% weight		
Wage Growth		66
15% weight		
Cost of Living		67
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		80
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		64
10% weight		
Days on Market		64
5% weight		
Office Economy		78
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 2.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +10.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 50 days median, +6.4% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.82, and its low unemployment rate of 2.80%, which signals a tight labor market. These metrics, combined with a moderate cost of living, make Atlanta an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate of +0.21% year-over-year, combined with a +1.222% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, signals genuine demand expansion. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.82, ranking in the 72nd percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.80% is exceptionally low, ranking in the 88th percentile, which means the labor market is very tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.22% is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses should factor in higher labor costs when considering Atlanta as a location.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 5.36, based on \$199/sqft and \$37.13/hr, Atlanta ranks in the 67th percentile, making it relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living. The moderate cost of living makes Atlanta an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.86% year-over-year, ranking in the 80th percentile, which indicates that the workforce supply is expanding. This growth in the labor force suggests that businesses will have access to a increasing pool of potential employees, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +10.47%, ranking in the 64th percentile, which signals that housing supply is expanding. This expansion in housing supply is a positive indicator for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in its infrastructure to support growing demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.4%, ranking in the 64th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, with homes taking slightly longer to sell. For workers relocating to Atlanta, this means that the market is becoming more accessible, with more time to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.36, ranking in the 78th percentile, Atlanta has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, while it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and moderate cost of living, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for upward pressure on wages due to the tight labor market, which may impact labor costs and overall competitiveness.

Kansas City

Kansas City

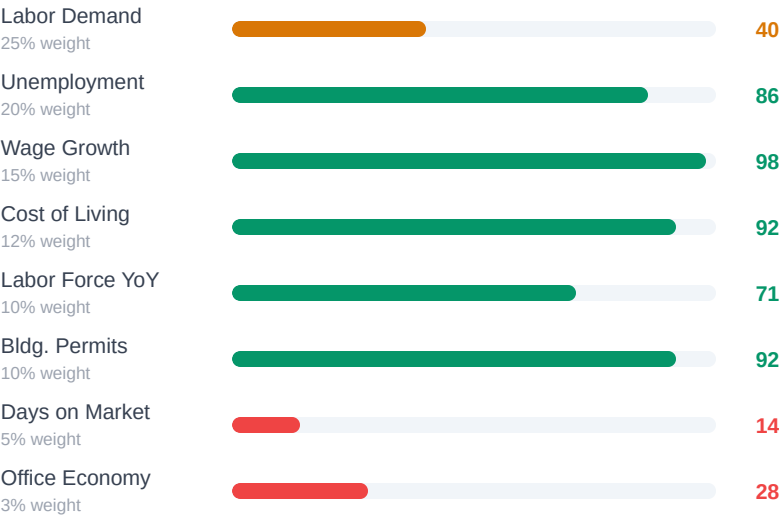
A+

EXCELLENT

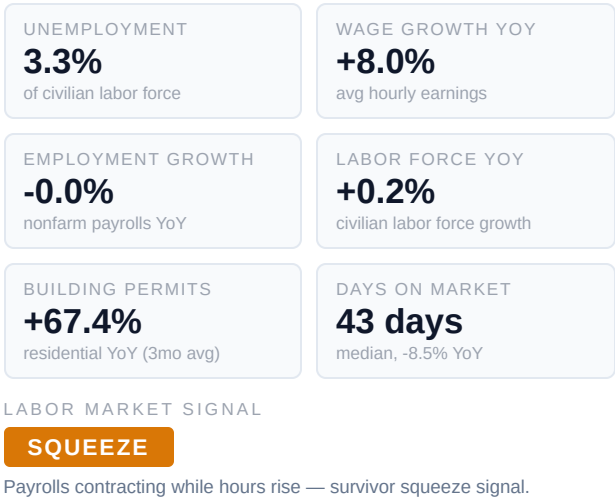
70.7th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.7th percentile, ranking it among the top metros in the US. The city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptionally high wage growth rate of 7.97% year-over-year and its top-tier unemployment rate of 3.30%, which together signal a highly competitive labor market. These metrics suggest that Kansas City is an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's labor demand composite score is near median at 40th percentile, driven by a slight decline in employment growth of -0.03% year-over-year and a modest increase in weekly hours of +0.421% versus its own trend. This combination signals a relatively stable labor market with no strong indication of either genuine demand expansion or contraction. The hours deviation suggests that workers are shouldering a slightly heavier load, but not to an extent that indicates a survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate stands at 3.30%, placing it in the top tier at the 86th percentile, which indicates a very tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses looking to hire in Kansas City may face significant competition for talent, potentially driving up wage costs. However, it also suggests a highly skilled and motivated workforce, which can be a major advantage for companies that can attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.97%, Kansas City is experiencing rapid wage inflation, ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This signals strong labor cost growth for employers, but also indicates a highly attractive market for workers with rising purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for increasing labor costs, but can also expect to tap into a workforce with growing disposable income and consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 92nd, driven by a PSF to earnings ratio of \$199/sqft versus \$36.17/hr, which equals 5.50. Although PSF is rising slightly at +0.5% year-over-year, the city remains an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain workers without breaking the bank.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of +0.25% year-over-year, placing it above average at the 71st percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding, which should support hiring capacity and reduce the risk of labor shortages. However, the growth rate is not exceptionally high, suggesting that businesses may still face some competition for talent in certain sectors.

Building Permits

Kansas City is experiencing a surge in residential building permits, with a year-over-year increase of +67.43%, ranking it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This signals a significant expansion in housing supply, which should improve affordability and support workforce growth in the coming years. As a result, businesses can expect a more accessible and attractive market for relocating workers and their families.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Kansas City stands at 43 days, with a year-over-year decline of -8.5%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This indicates a highly competitive and fast-moving housing market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers trying to find affordable housing. However, it also suggests a strong and dynamic local economy with high demand for housing and a limited supply of available properties.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile, which suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. While the city may not be the best fit for businesses requiring a deep bench of tech, finance, or consulting talent, it could be an attractive location for companies in other industries, such as logistics or manufacturing, that can tap into its more diverse workforce.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with strong wage growth, a tight unemployment rate, and an affordable cost of living. However, the city's fast-moving housing market and limited supply of office talent may pose challenges for relocating workers and businesses with specific skill requirements. Overall, Kansas City is an attractive location for companies that can navigate its competitive labor market and tap into its growing and productive workforce.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

68.6th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		88
Unemployment 20% weight		71
Wage Growth 15% weight		28
Cost of Living 12% weight		76
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		69
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		60
Days on Market 5% weight		74
Office Economy 3% weight		82

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.5% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +9.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 47 days median, +6.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.6th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 6.66, and its high share of office and professional workers, ranking in the 82nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen employment growth of 1.08% year-over-year, combined with a 0.846% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, resulting in a top-tier labor demand composite score of 88th percentile. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours worked above trend. This is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.50%, ranking in the 71st percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. However, this also suggests a strong local economy with low unemployment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 2.06%, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating relatively slow wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but may also not see a significant boost in consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 76th, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$221/sqft to \$37.49/hr, or 5.89. The fact that the PSF is falling by 1.8% year-over-year relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses looking to recruit talent without having to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has grown by 0.17% year-over-year, ranking in the 69th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This means that businesses may have a slightly easier time finding workers, but the growth rate is not rapid enough to significantly alleviate hiring challenges.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has increased by 9.08% year-over-year, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating an expanding housing supply. This suggests that the city is likely to see improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for relocating workers in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is currently 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.8%, ranking in the 74th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

The share of office and professional workers in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is high, ranking in the 82nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for a variety of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively tight labor market, which may require businesses to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A

VERY GOOD

67.3th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		82
Unemployment 20% weight		74
Wage Growth 15% weight		74
Cost of Living 12% weight		57
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		63
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		22
Days on Market 5% weight		60
Office Economy 3% weight		88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -18.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 52 days median, +6.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier labor demand composite score of 6.01, driven by employment growth of +0.28% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +1.321% from its own trend. These metrics signal a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.28% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +1.321% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The labor demand composite score of 6.01, ranking in the 82th percentile, further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.00% is relatively low, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which could lead to upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.81% is relatively high, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating strong wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but workers will have increased purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. The high wage growth rate also indicates a competitive labor market, where businesses may need to offer higher wages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is near median, with a percentile rank of 57th, and a PSF to earnings ratio of \$263/sqft to \$35.91/hr, or 7.32. The city's cost of living is relatively affordable, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living. The slight decline in PSF of -0.8% YoY also suggests that the city's affordability is improving.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.02% YoY, which is a relatively slow expansion. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a moderate pace, which may not keep up with demand. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may still face challenges in finding talent, especially in certain industries or skill sets.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -18.82%, indicating a decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city's housing market may be tightening, which could lead to increased competition for housing and higher prices. The decline in building permits also signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing is not keeping up with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.1%. This indicates a relatively slow market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is more accessible, and they may have more time to find a home that meets their needs.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.74, ranking in the 88th percentile. This makes Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. The city's strong office economy is a major advantage for businesses looking to tap into this talent pool.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers a strong labor market, a deep professional talent pool, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the decline in building permits, which may lead to a tightening housing market and increased competition for talent, making it essential to factor in the potential impact on workforce accommodation and affordability.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

65.0th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and highly affordable cost of living, as evidenced by a 94th percentile cost of living score and an 86th percentile wage growth rate of 6.75%. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a competitive yet attractive environment for businesses and workers alike. With a cost of living ratio of \$240/sqft to \$37.61/hr, or 6.38, this city offers an unusual combination of affordability and economic vitality.

Labor Demand

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has seen employment growth of 0.63% year-over-year, combined with a -0.498% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.68, which ranks near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some degree of labor market slack. However, the overall labor demand picture is one of gentle growth rather than contraction or survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos stands at 3.40%, ranking in the 65th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This rate suggests that while it may be slightly harder for businesses to hire, the market is not overly competitive, and wage pressure is moderate. For a business trying to hire in this market, the implication is that they may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 6.75%, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as it allows them to keep pace with the cost of living and enjoy a high standard of living. However, for employers, this means that labor costs are likely to continue rising, potentially squeezing profit margins.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living score in the 94th percentile, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is highly affordable relative to its peers, driven by a PSF of \$240/sqft that has fallen 8.1% year-over-year relative to wages of \$37.61/hr. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has grown 0.54% year-over-year, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is strong, with a growing pool of potential workers to draw from. As the labor force continues to expand, businesses can expect to find the talent they need to grow and thrive.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has fallen 22.85% year-over-year, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing fails to keep pace with demand. This could lead to upward pressure on housing costs and rents, potentially eroding the city's affordability advantage.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is currently 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of 21.7%, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This suggests a slowing market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this trend also indicates a potential normalization of the market, rather than a demand-driven slowdown.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the 92nd percentile, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a deep and talented pool of knowledge workers, making it an attractive location for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized professional talent, but may be less suitable for companies with primarily industrial or logistics-focused operations.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordability, and a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the decline in residential building permits, which threatens to erode the city's affordability advantage and create future workforce accommodation challenges.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

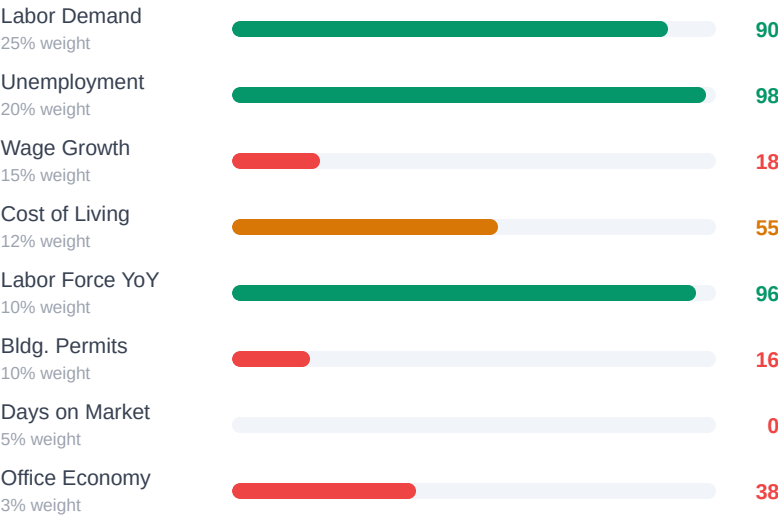
A

VERY GOOD

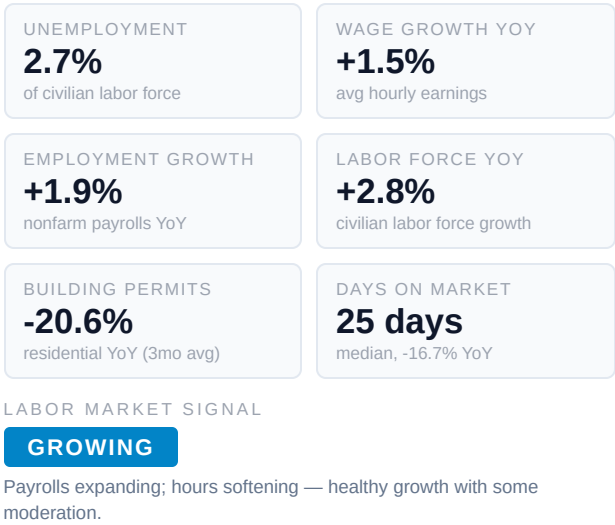
63.7th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier labor demand and extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%. The city's economic character is defined by its strong employment growth and tight labor market, with a labor demand composite score of 6.66, placing it in the 90th percentile. This suggests a city with genuine demand expansion, where businesses can capitalize on a growing workforce.

Labor Demand

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has seen employment growth of 1.88% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.272% from its own 12-month baseline, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked remaining relatively stable, suggesting that the growth is not solely due to existing workers taking on more hours. The labor demand composite score of 6.66, in the 90th percentile, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford stands at 2.70%, placing it in the 98th percentile, indicating an extremely tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies that workers have significant bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 1.48%, ranking in the 18th percentile, indicating relatively slow wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers may not have strong bargaining power, potentially limiting their purchasing power. The slow wage growth may make it easier for businesses to manage labor costs, but it could also impact the local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living score in the 55th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$254/sqft to \$39.73/hr, or 6.39. The fact that the PSF is falling by 1.6% year-over-year relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of 2.77% year-over-year, placing it in the 96th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees. The expanding labor force also implies that the city is likely to have a more dynamic and diverse workforce.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has decreased by 20.59% year-over-year, ranking in the 16th percentile. This decline suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city. The decrease in building permits may signal a potential constraint on the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 25 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 16.7%, placing it in the 0th percentile. This extremely fast pace of home sales suggests a highly competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The rapid sales pace implies that the city's housing market is highly sought after, potentially driving up prices and making it less accessible to new residents.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has an office economy score in the 38th percentile, indicating a below-average share of professional and office workers. This suggests that the city may not be the best fit for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to capitalize on a growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it challenging for workers to relocate to the city.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

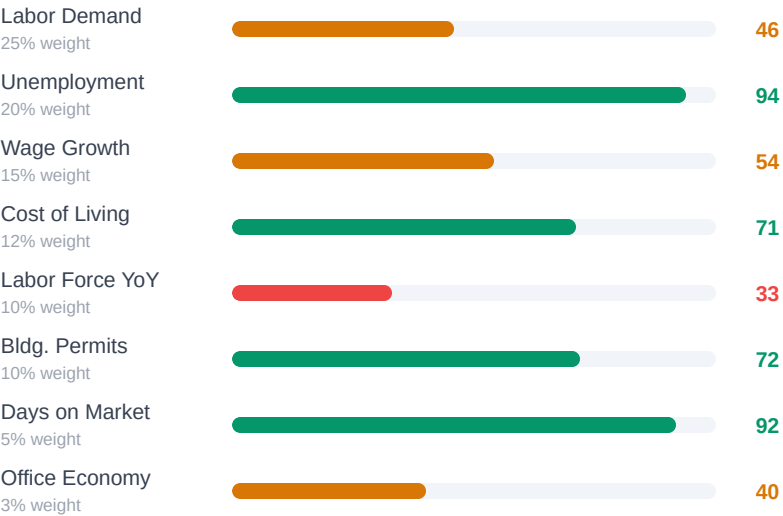
A

VERY GOOD

63.2th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and a strong building permits growth of +16.86% YoY. These two metrics most define the city's current economic character, suggesting a tight labor market and an expanding housing supply. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.60, although near the median, is influenced by a modest employment growth rate of +0.30% YoY.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate of +0.30% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.124% from its own trend, signals a moderate labor demand expansion, rather than a strong one, as hours are not running significantly above trend. This suggests that while jobs are being added, the existing workforce is not being overly utilized. The labor demand composite score of 4.60 reflects this balanced but not exceptional growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.10%, placing it in the top tier with a 94th percentile rank, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, leading to potential wage pressure. Companies looking to staff up may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +4.25% YoY, ranking near the median with a 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. This balance is generally favorable for businesses looking to manage labor expenses without sacrificing worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living, with a PSF of \$195/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.36, results in a ratio that places it in the 71st percentile for affordability. This means the city is more affordable than many of its peers, which can be a significant talent attraction advantage without needing to offer wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising only +1.0% YoY relative to wages contributes to its relatively high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking at a rate of -1.12% YoY, indicating a contracting labor pool. This negative growth rate poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to compete more effectively for a smaller pool of candidates.

Building Permits

The city saw a +16.86% YoY increase in building permits, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in residential construction is a positive indicator for future affordability and suggests that the city is likely to accommodate workforce growth without significant housing cost pressures.

Days on Market

Homes in Cincinnati are currently sitting on the market for 36 days, with a +9.1% YoY increase in days on market, placing it in the top tier with a 92nd percentile rank. This slower market means that relocating workers may find it easier to find and purchase a home, as the market is less competitive compared to faster-moving markets.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share, ranked in the 40th percentile, indicates a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses requiring specialized roles, though it may not be as deep as in cities with a higher concentration of tech, finance, or consulting industries. The city is well-suited for a variety of businesses but may be less ideal for those requiring an extremely high concentration of professional talent.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique blend of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to balance labor costs with access to a skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may necessitate innovative recruitment and retention strategies to secure the necessary talent.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

A-

GOOD

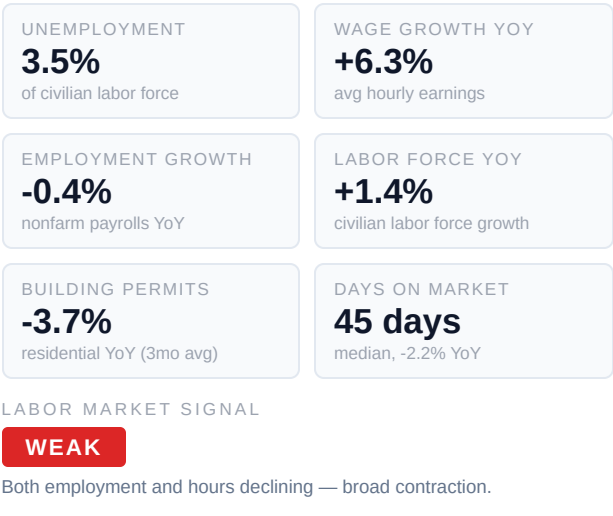
62.6th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.6th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.34%, and its low unemployment rate of 3.50%, which ranks in the 78th percentile. These metrics suggest a competitive labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.43% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.173% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.70, which ranks below average at the 34th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth rate indicates a shrinking number of jobs.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.50%, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.34%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 82, indicating that the city is more affordable than most of its peers. The current PSF is \$172/sqft, with a ratio of 5.11 to average hourly earnings of \$33.65/hr. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction strategy for businesses, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.38% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a increasing pool of potential workers. The expanding labor force can help mitigate the challenges posed by the low unemployment rate.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Pittsburgh is decreasing by 3.72% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in building permits may signal future affordability challenges and limitations in workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Pittsburgh is 45 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.2%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for homebuyers, which may pose challenges for workers relocating to the city. The fast-paced market may require relocating workers to act quickly to secure housing.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share is ranked near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent pool in these sectors. The city is relatively well-suited for businesses that require a mix of industrial, logistics, and office-based workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, low unemployment, and an expanding labor force supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a talented and growing workforce. However, the city's tightening housing supply and competitive housing market may pose challenges for relocating workers, and businesses should factor in these constraints when making location decisions.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

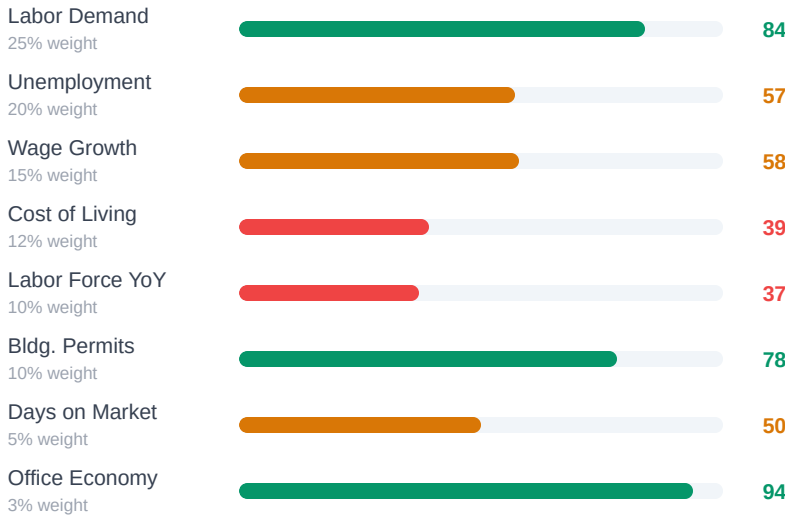
A-

GOOD

62.6th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.1%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+23.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, +2.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 84th percentile, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking at the 94th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.33% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.047% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has a labor demand composite score of 6.12, driven by a 1.33% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.047% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not significantly above trend despite job growth. The strong labor demand indicates a competitive job market with many opportunities for workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 3.60%, ranking at the 57th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that the market is not extremely tight, but still relatively competitive, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure, but it is not as intense as in cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.31%, ranking at the 58th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth provides a relatively stable environment for businesses to operate, without extreme pressure on labor costs.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Salt Lake City-Murray is relatively high, with a percentile rank of 39th, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$266/sqft to \$39.12/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.80. This means that the city is less affordable compared to its peers, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent. However, the relatively high cost of living may also indicate a strong local economy with high demand for housing.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is contracting at a rate of -1.05% year-over-year, ranking at the 37th percentile. This contraction indicates that the labor pool is shrinking, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result,

businesses may need to invest in talent development and retention strategies to overcome the limited labor supply.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Salt Lake City-Murray has increased by 23.54% year-over-year, ranking at the 78th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rising permits also indicate developer confidence in the local market, which may lead to increased economic activity.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%, ranking at the 50th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising days on market may also signal a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.32, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating a deep and specialized talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of professional workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and a growing housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech and finance sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the shrinking labor pool, which may pose challenges for hiring and expansion, and require investments in talent development and retention strategies.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

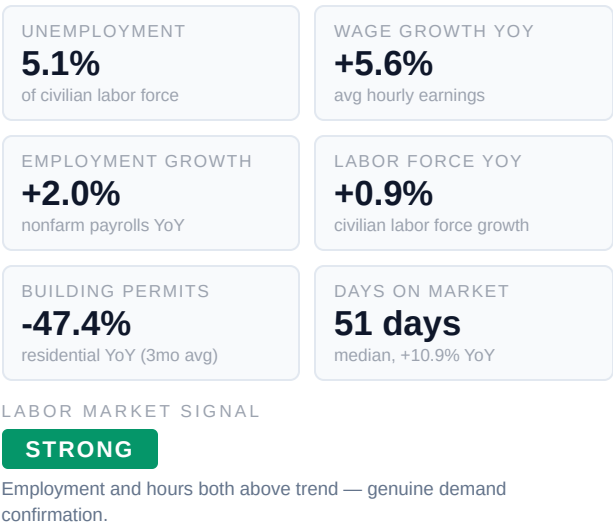
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.8th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with a composite score at the 94th percentile, driven by a 2.04% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.024% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. The combination of strong employment growth and hours worked above trend signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has seen a 2.04% year-over-year employment growth rate, coupled with a 0.024% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.18 further reinforces this, ranking at the 94th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas stands at 5.10%, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating a below-average performance. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find candidates, the local consumer demand might be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.63%, ranking at the 70th percentile, indicating above-average wage growth. This signals that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. The moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that businesses should be prepared for rising labor costs, but also recognize the potential for increased consumer spending.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$264/sqft to \$33.16/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 2.2% in PSF, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas ranks at the 45th percentile in terms of affordability. This suggests that the city is near the median in terms of cost of living, neither extremely affordable nor overly expensive. The relatively stable affordability means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but it does not provide a strong talent attraction advantage either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has grown by 0.95% year-over-year, ranking at the 84th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential candidates. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses are likely to find a sufficient supply of workers, supporting their growth plans.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is -47.38%, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating a sharp decline. This signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The significant drop in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a readily available and affordable housing supply for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.9%, ranking at the 80th percentile. This suggests a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For a worker relocating to this city, the slower market could make it easier to find a home, as there is less competition and pressure to make quick decisions.

Office Economy

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite score ranking at the 86th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, it may be less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand environment, with genuine expansion and a growing workforce supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in residential building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's otherwise favorable economic conditions.

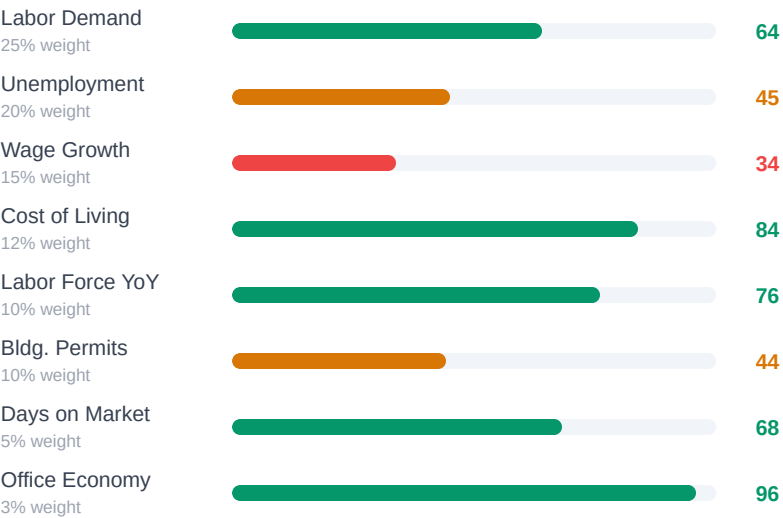
Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

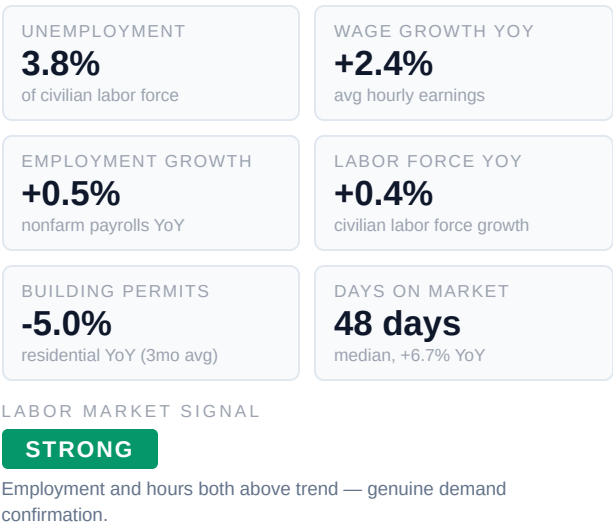
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.4th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 64th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 84th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 0.51% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.186% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of 0.51% employment growth and 0.186% hours deviation above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are increasing, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.20 further supports this assessment, ranking at the 64th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.80%, ranking at the 45th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, and businesses may face some challenges in hiring. However, the unemployment rate is not excessively high, providing a moderate level of availability of potential employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 2.44%, ranking at the 34th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a relatively slow pace, and worker purchasing power is growing, albeit not rapidly. The moderate wage growth may help attract and retain workers without significantly increasing labor costs.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 84, driven by a PSF of \$203/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.61, resulting in a ratio of 5.40. The PSF has decreased by 1.9% year-over-year, contributing to the high affordability score. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has grown by 0.41% year-over-year, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the labor pool is increasing, providing a positive environment for hiring and business expansion. The growing labor force can help support business growth and reduce the risk of labor shortages.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has decreased by 4.95% year-over-year, ranking at the 44th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decrease may signal future affordability challenges and potential constraints on workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The decline in building permits may lead to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is currently 48 days, with a 6.7% year-over-year increase, ranking at the 68th percentile. This increase suggests a slowing market, which can make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the relatively moderate days on market still indicates a competitive housing market, and workers may face some challenges in finding suitable housing.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is ranked at the 96th percentile, indicating a deep and specialized talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of professional and office workers. However, it may be less suitable for businesses with primarily industrial or logistics-based operations.

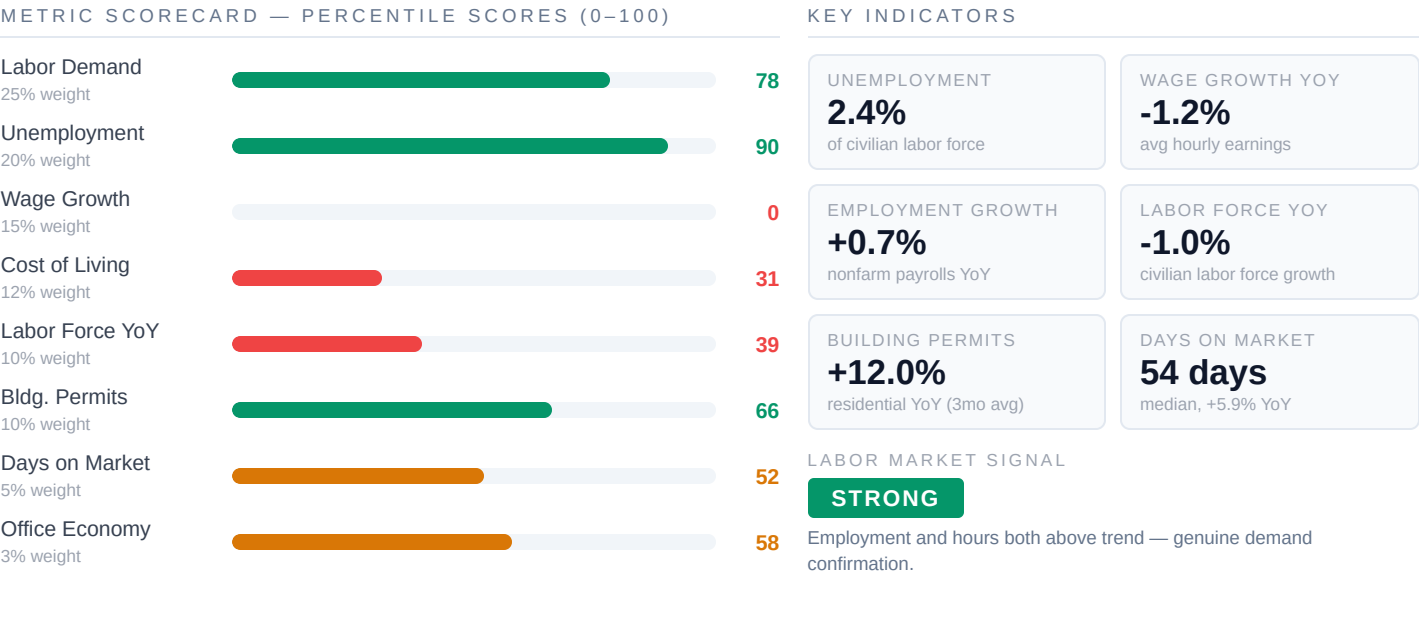
The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and growing labor force, making it an attractive location for expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, driven by a decline in residential building permits, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Birmingham

Birmingham

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.0th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 56.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its low unemployment rate, which ranks in the 90th percentile at 2.40%. These metrics suggest a city with a tight labor market and genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate is +0.66% year-over-year, combined with a +0.680% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.90 further supports this interpretation, indicating a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 2.40%, ranking in the 90th percentile and indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there is limited slack in the market. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Birmingham is -1.22% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power may not be increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living is below average, with a percentile rank of 31 and a price-to-salary ratio of \$161/sqft to \$32.72/hr, or 4.92. However, the fact that the PSF is not falling YoY means that affordability is not improving. This relatively low affordability score means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -1.03% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Birmingham are increasing by +12.01% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that affordability may improve in the future, and the city may become more attractive to relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Birmingham is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.9%. This rising DOM indicates a slowing market, which may become more accessible to relocating workers. However, the current median days on market is still relatively low, suggesting that the market remains competitive.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional talent pool is near median, with a percentile rank of 58. This suggests that the city has a moderate depth of knowledge-economy talent, making it suited for a variety of businesses, but perhaps not ideal for those requiring a highly specialized or deep talent pool.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a strong labor demand environment and a tight labor market, but also presents challenges in terms of hiring and wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's stagnant wage growth and shrinking labor force, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and drive up labor costs in the long term.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

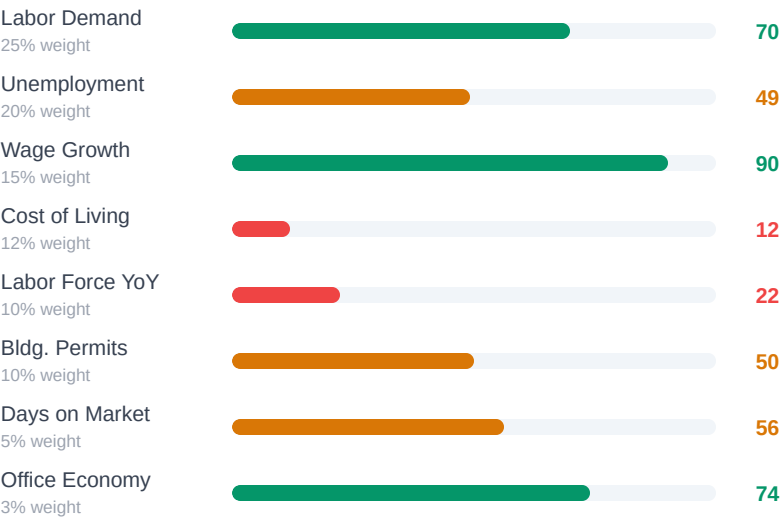
B

AVERAGE

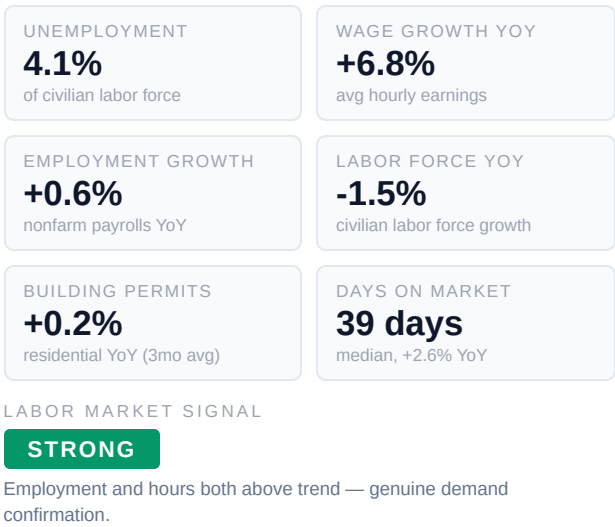
54.5th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 54.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and labor demand. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 6.85% year-over-year and its above-average labor demand composite score of 5.50, which signals genuine demand expansion. These metrics indicate a city with a strong and growing economy.

Labor Demand

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.64% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.303% above its own trend, combining to form an above-average labor demand composite score. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor market is characterized by an increase in jobs and working hours, indicating a strong demand for labor.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.10%, ranking near the median at the 49th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may be manageable, but not overly easy, and may require competitive offers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 6.85%, placing it in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also strong worker purchasing power. As wages continue to rise, businesses may face increasing costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living percentile rank of 12, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$604/sqft to \$43.04/hr, or 14.03. Although PSF is falling by 4.0% year-over-year, the city remains expensive. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking at a rate of -1.52% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding and recruiting new talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is +0.17%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This slight increase in permits suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which may help improve affordability and accommodate the workforce in the future. However, the modest growth rate may not be enough to keep pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This indicates a near-median market pace, where homes are selling at a moderate speed. For a worker relocating to this city, the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible, offering a relatively balanced environment for homebuyers.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an office economy percentile rank of 74, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations that require specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy with top-tier wage growth, but also poses challenges due to its expensive cost of living and shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's strong labor demand and wage growth.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

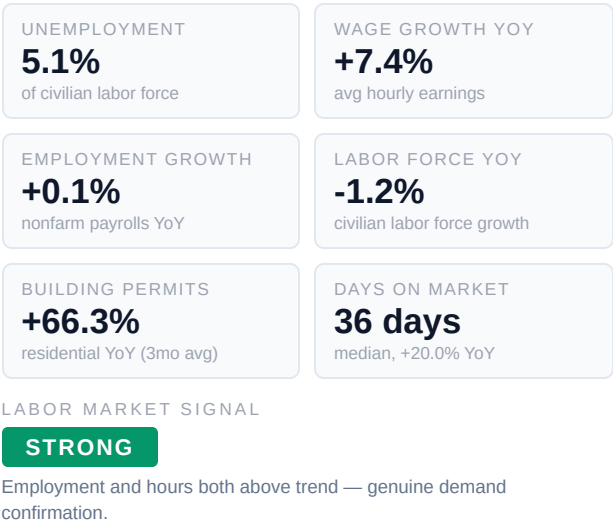
54.2th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and office economy. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.37% year-over-year and its significant share of office and professional workers, ranking in the 84th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong knowledge-based economy.

Labor Demand

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.08% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.67% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.08 ranks in the 60th percentile, further supporting the notion of a strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.10%, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate puts upward pressure on wages. The tight market implies that employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 7.37%, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, while also benefiting from a workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue, with a price-to-salary ratio of 9.50, ranks in the 41st percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The fact that the price per square foot is falling by 3.6% year-over-year, at \$452/sqft, relative to hourly earnings of \$47.57, suggests a relatively stable affordability environment. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to affordability, as it is neither particularly expensive nor unusually affordable compared to its peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking by 1.17% year-over-year, ranking in the 31st percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force growth suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 66.30% year-over-year, ranking in the 90th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This rapid growth in permits suggests that the city's housing market is poised for increased affordability and accommodation of its workforce. As a result, businesses may benefit from a more stable and affordable housing environment for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of 20.0%, ranking in the 98th percentile. This slow-down in the housing market, with homes taking longer to sell, may indicate a more accessible and less competitive environment for workers relocating to the city. However, this also suggests a potential normalization of the market, rather than a sign of demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of office and professional workers in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue ranks in the 84th percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of knowledge-based workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses seeking to tap into a skilled and professional workforce.

In conclusion, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue offers businesses a strong knowledge-based economy with high wage growth and a deep talent pool, but also presents challenges due to its tight labor market and moderate affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which may require businesses to adapt their hiring strategies and consider the potential impact on their operations.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B

AVERAGE

54.1th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		74
25% weight		
Unemployment		63
20% weight		
Wage Growth		84
15% weight		
Cost of Living		16
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		10
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		52
10% weight		
Days on Market		4
5% weight		
Office Economy		66
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -2.4% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +0.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 32 days median, -8.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and high wage growth, scoring 74th and 84th percentiles respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with employment growth at 0.34% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.065% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.34% year-over-year, combined with weekly hours 1.065% above trend, indicates a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in economic activity, with businesses hiring more workers and existing employees working more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.84, ranking in the 74th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 3.90%, ranking in the 63rd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.70%, ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. The high wage growth rate may attract top talent to the area, but also increases the cost of doing business.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is relatively high, with a percentile rank of 16, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$664/sqft to \$50.65/hr, or 13.11. Although the price per square foot is falling by 3.5% year-over-year, the city remains expensive. This may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset the benefits of working in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.44% year-over-year, ranking in the 10th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction may create a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is 0.83%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, indicating a modest expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is stable, and future housing supply may be expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 32 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.6%, ranking in the 4th percentile. This indicates a highly competitive market, where homes are selling quickly. For workers relocating to the city, this may mean a challenging and competitive housing market, with limited options and rapid sales.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.06, ranking in the 66th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy talent, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers a strong labor market with high wage growth, making it an attractive location for businesses that require specialized talent. However, the high cost of living and competitive housing market may pose significant challenges for attracting and retaining workers, and the shrinking labor pool may create hiring difficulties, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

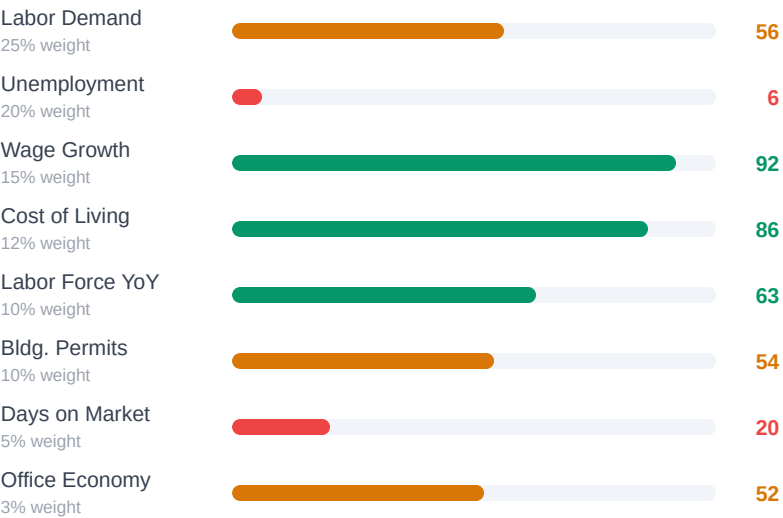
B

AVERAGE

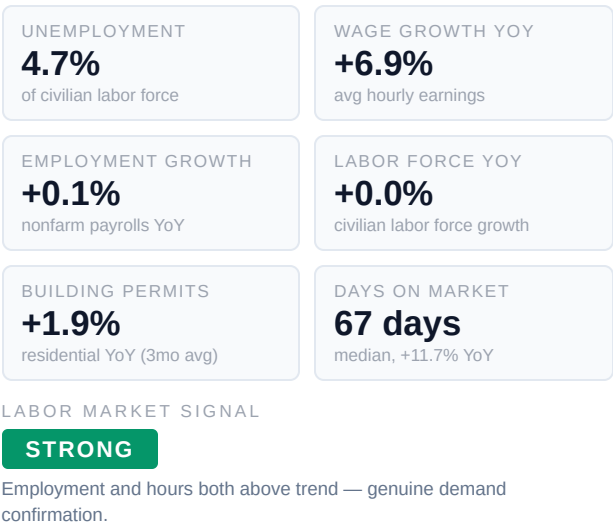
53.6th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 53.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and affordable cost of living, scoring 92nd and 86th percentiles respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with a wage growth rate of 6.90% and a cost of living ratio of \$241/sqft to \$37.36/hr, indicating a relatively affordable environment. This combination suggests a city with a strong labor market and attractive conditions for workers.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 0.12% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.409% above its own 12-month baseline, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.88 places the city near the median, 56th percentile, indicating a stable but not exceptionally strong labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 6.90%, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees see their earnings increase, but it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control. The high wage growth rate suggests that the city is an attractive location for workers, but may require businesses to adjust their compensation packages accordingly.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of \$241/sqft to \$37.36/hr, with the price per square foot falling 3.2% year-over-year, making it an affordable city, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling price per square foot relative to wages is a key driver of the city's high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.02% year-over-year, placing it above average at the 63rd percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This means that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which can help support business growth and hiring needs. However, the slow growth rate may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to labor shortages in certain industries.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is increasing by 1.87% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a moderate expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing a gradual increase in housing development, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the moderate growth rate may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 67 days, with a year-over-year increase of 11.7%, ranking below average at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. This means that homes are selling quickly, making it a competitive market for workers relocating to the city, who may face challenges in finding affordable housing. The fast-paced market may require workers to act quickly to secure housing, potentially driving up prices.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a professional and office worker share of 2.66, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and office workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or technical workforce. The city's office economy is relatively balanced, making it a viable location for a range of businesses.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with attractive conditions for workers, driven by its high wage growth and affordable cost of living. However, the city's tight labor market and low unemployment rate may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire, making it essential to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential for labor shortages and rising labor costs, which could impact their ability to grow and operate effectively.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

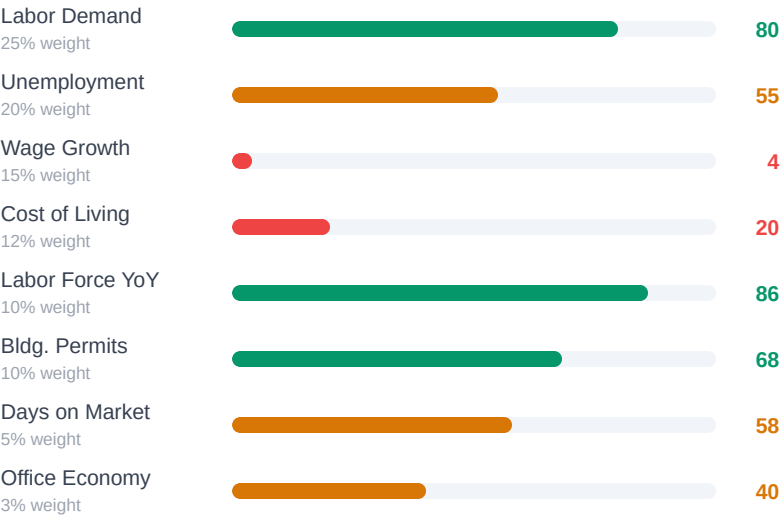
B

AVERAGE

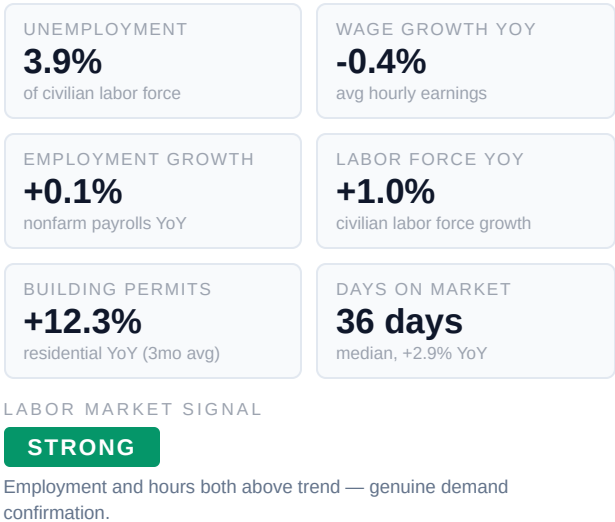
53.5th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, which are in the top tier at the 80th and 86th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.92, combining a +0.12% employment growth rate and a +1.451% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This is further supported by a labor force growth rate of +1.02% YoY.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.12% and weekly hours deviation of +1.451% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in economic activity, leading to more jobs being added. The labor demand composite score of 5.92 is in the top tier, at the 80th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.90% is near the median, ranking at the 55th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be overly challenging, but it also may not be extremely easy, as the market is not particularly loose. This rate implies a stable environment for hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.37% is in the bottom tier, at the 4th percentile, indicating stagnant or even slightly decreasing wages. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers, potentially affecting their purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean lower labor costs, but it also suggests workers may have less disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$233/sqft to \$32.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.10, and a percentile rank of 20th, the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that the PSF is not falling YoY (with a 0.0% change) does not help improve affordability. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging due to the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.02% YoY, which is in the top tier, at the 86th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, suggesting a favorable environment for hiring, as there is an increasing pool of potential employees. This growth supports the city's ability to accommodate business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +12.30%, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future. It suggests developer confidence in the market.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.9%. This indicates a near median market speed, ranked at the 58th percentile. For a worker relocating to this city, the relatively moderate days on market suggests a competitive but not overly challenging housing market, making it accessible for newcomers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 2.38, places the city near the median, at the 40th percentile, in terms of its talent pool depth. This suggests that while the city has some professional and office workers, it is not particularly specialized in these areas, making it less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and expanding labor force, which are significant advantages for companies looking to grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the relatively high cost of living, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

B

AVERAGE

52.8th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		96
Unemployment 20% weight		74
Wage Growth 15% weight		6
Cost of Living 12% weight		2
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		29
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		62
Days on Market 5% weight		24
Office Economy 3% weight		90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY 0.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +9.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 29 days median, +7.4% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier labor demand and office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.35, combining a 1.32% employment growth rate and a 1.205% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, along with its high share of professional and office workers, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen a 1.32% employment growth rate year-over-year, coupled with a 1.205% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating a strong and genuine demand for labor. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth where hours are also increasing, suggesting that businesses are expanding their operations and workers are taking on more hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to locate in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area stands at 3.70%, ranking in the 74th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This tight market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, it also suggests a strong local economy with low levels of unemployment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 0.00%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to control costs. However, it may also indicate weak bargaining power for workers and potentially slower growth in consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area, with a price per square foot of \$844 and average hourly earnings of \$54.13, results in a ratio of 15.59, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile in terms of affordability. This low affordability ranking means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has contracted by 1.19% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 29th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply indicates that the pool of potential workers is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for businesses looking to hire in the area. This trend may require businesses to be more competitive in their hiring practices or to consider relocation strategies.

Building Permits

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen a 9.92% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future. This is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.4%, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find and purchase homes. However, the slight increase in days on market may signal a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with a composite score ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. However, it may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the high cost of living, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting some of the benefits of locating in this area.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

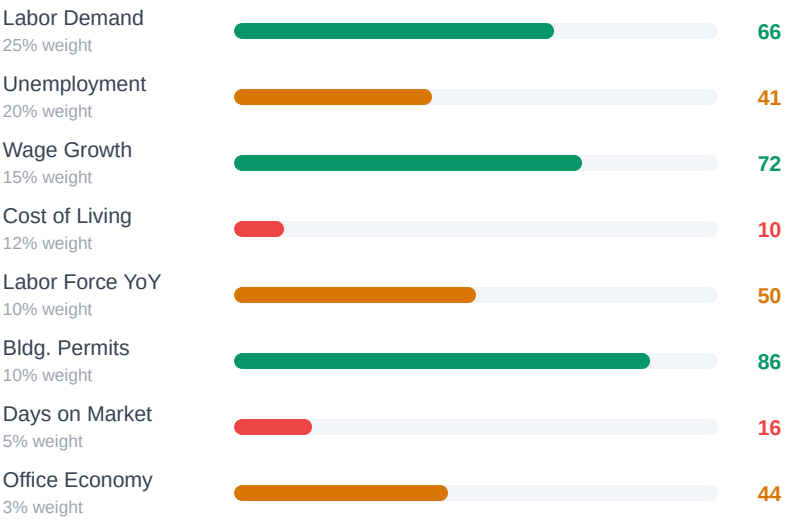
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AVERAGE

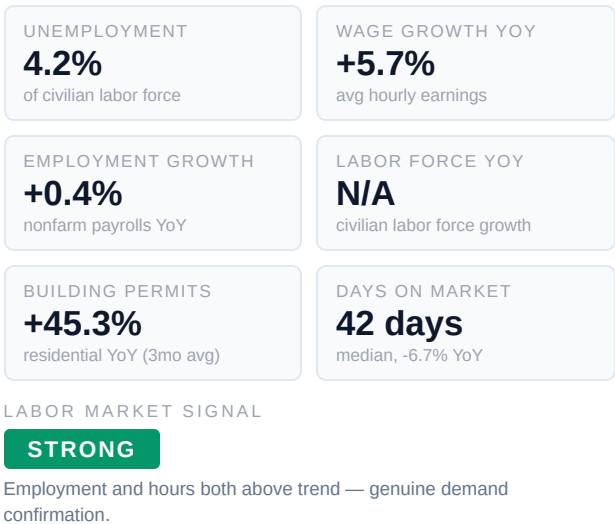
52.4th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 52.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 66th and 72nd percentiles, respectively. The city's labor market is characterized by a 0.39% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.456% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. These metrics define the city's current economic character, signaling a moderate expansion in job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.39% and weekly hours 0.456% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in job opportunities, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are absorbing the additional workload. This is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.20%, ranking near the median at the 41st percentile. This rate indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the relatively higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 5.68%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increased purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. This is a significant factor for businesses to consider when evaluating labor costs and potential returns on investment.

Cost of Living

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a cost of living score that ranks at the 10th percentile, with a PSF of \$532/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$41.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 12.94. This low percentile rank indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The slight decrease in PSF of 0.2% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall cost of living remains a significant constraint.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force growth rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is not available, but it is ranked near the median at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the workforce supply is neither expanding nor contracting significantly, which may imply a stable but not

particularly dynamic labor market. This stability can be beneficial for businesses looking for a predictable workforce, but it may also limit the potential for rapid growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 45.32%, ranking at the 86th percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 42 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 6.7%. This relatively fast market, ranked at the 16th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. This fast pace may require businesses to provide relocation assistance or adjust their hiring timelines accordingly.

Office Economy

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an office economy score that ranks at the 44th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.40 out of 5. This near-median rank suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it suitable for businesses in these industries, such as tech, finance, or consulting. However, it may not be as competitive for businesses in industrial or logistics sectors.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a unique combination of moderate job growth, strong wage growth, and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies in professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially impacting business profitability and competitiveness.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

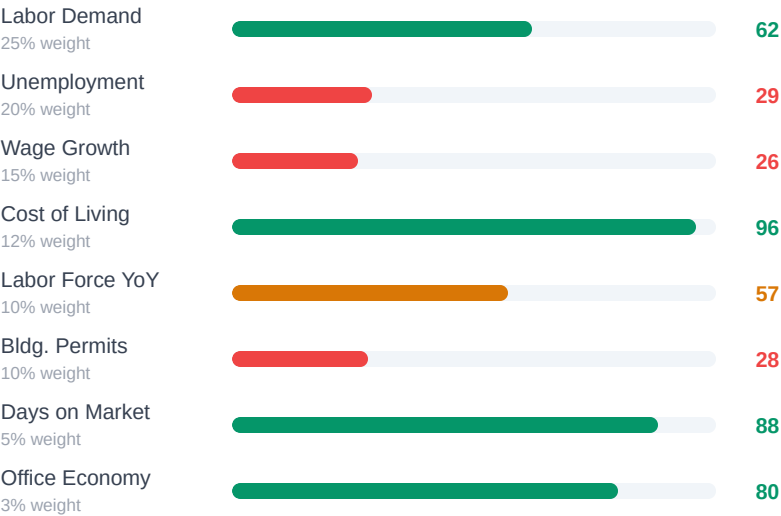
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AVERAGE

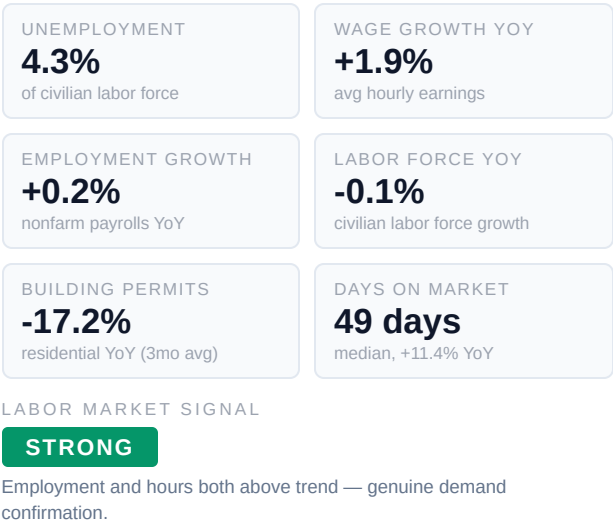
51.9th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 51.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and highly affordable cost of living, scoring in the 96th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 5.18, combining a 0.22% employment growth rate and a 0.569% weekly hours deviation above trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with a cost of living ratio of \$173/sqft to \$36.90/hr, indicates a favorable environment for businesses and workers alike.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.22% and weekly hours deviation of 0.569% above trend signal genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the labor market is experiencing real growth, rather than just a redistribution of existing work. The labor demand composite score of 5.18, ranking in the 62nd percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is below average, ranking in the 29th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as potential upward pressure on wages. In practical terms, a business trying to hire in this market may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.85% is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile, suggesting moderate wage growth. This rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other metros. For workers, this means that purchasing power is increasing, but not as rapidly as in areas with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$173/sqft to \$36.90/hr and a percentile rank of 96, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is highly affordable relative to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.3% YoY further enhances affordability. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can recruit and retain workers without needing to offer large wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.05% year-over-year, ranking near the median in the 57th percentile, indicating a very slight contraction in the labor pool. This minimal contraction suggests that the hiring capacity may be somewhat limited, but the impact is likely to

be small.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -17.22%, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of 11.4%, ranking in the 88th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making the market more accessible for relocating workers who have more time to find a home.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the 80th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but may be less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

In conclusion, the Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of labor demand, affordability, and access to a professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

51.4th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		86
Unemployment 20% weight		18
Wage Growth 15% weight		60
Cost of Living 12% weight		6
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		20
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		96
Days on Market 5% weight		62
Office Economy 3% weight		60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force N/A	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.8% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.6% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +80.0% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 47 days median, +4.4% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and building permits growth. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier labor demand composite score of 6.14, which combines a +1.83% employment growth rate and a -0.727% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. This signals a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.83% and weekly hours deviation of -0.727% combine to signal a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked. This suggests that businesses are hiring and workers are putting in more hours, which is a positive sign for the local economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.14 is in the top tier, ranking 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is not available, but the bottom tier percentile rank of 18th suggests that the market may have some slack. This could make it easier for businesses to hire workers, as there may be a larger pool of available labor. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may not face as much competition for talent as it would in a tighter market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.84% is above average, ranking 60th percentile. This indicates that wages are rising at a moderate pace, which could lead to increased labor costs for employers. However, it also means that workers have more purchasing power, which could be beneficial for local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living percentile rank of 6th, with a PSF of \$667/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$41.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.98. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, which could make it difficult to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.0% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score is still low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.55% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking 20th percentile. This suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which could make it more difficult for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may need to offer more competitive wages and benefits to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +79.98%, which is in the top tier, ranking 96th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding rapidly, which could lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for workers. The signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation is positive, as the increased supply of housing could help to reduce costs and make the city more competitive.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of +4.4%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down slightly, which could make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The above-average percentile rank of 62nd suggests that the market is still relatively competitive, but the rising DOM could indicate a healthy normalization.

Office Economy

The city has an office economy percentile rank of 60th, with a share of professional and office workers of 2.96. This suggests that the city has a deep talent pool in these sectors, making it well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. However, it may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and expanding housing supply, which could make it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the relatively high cost of living, which could make it difficult to attract talent without offering wage premiums. Overall, businesses should carefully consider these factors when making a location decision.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

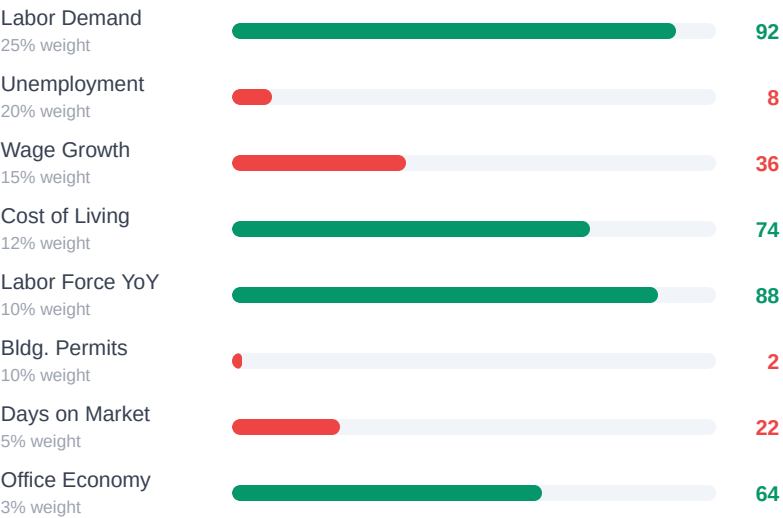
B

AVERAGE

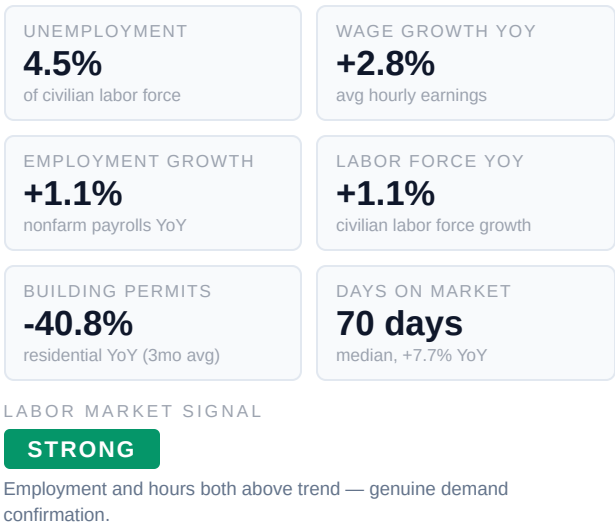
50.8th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, at 92nd and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours deviation of 1.057%, indicating genuine demand expansion. With a labor demand composite score of 6.87, the city is experiencing a significant increase in job openings and hours worked.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours deviation of 1.057% signal genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a strong increase in labor demand, with businesses adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 6.87 is in the top tier, at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.50% is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, as there is a larger pool of available labor. However, the higher unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.81% is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. The moderate wage growth suggests a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living score of 74th percentile, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.47/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.69. The PSF is falling by 3.5% year-over-year, making the city more affordable relative to peers. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.07% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This means that the city has a growing pool of available workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The labor force growth rate is in the top tier, at the 88th percentile.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -40.79%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city may be experiencing a supply squeeze, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. The low ranking of 2nd percentile indicates a significant constraint on future housing supply.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 70 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, indicating a slowing market. This means that homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers to relocate to the area. However, the below-average ranking of 22nd percentile suggests that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

The city has an office economy score of 64th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting industries, but less suitable for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a growing workforce supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. This constraint should be carefully considered by decision-makers when evaluating the city as a potential business location.

Columbus

Columbus

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.5th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		44
25% weight		
Unemployment		96
20% weight		
Wage Growth		42
15% weight		
Cost of Living		63
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		24
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		14
10% weight		
Days on Market		12
5% weight		
Office Economy		32
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 2.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.3% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.4% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -20.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 33 days median, -5.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 49.5th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 2.80% and a labor demand composite score of 4.36, which places it near the median. The city's economic character is also defined by its stagnant labor force growth and declining building permits. Specifically, the low unemployment rate and near-median labor demand score suggest a mixed economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.22% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.246% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as the modest job growth is not accompanied by a significant increase in hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 4.36, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 2.80%, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Columbus is +3.26%, which is near the median, ranking at the 42nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in Columbus are experiencing a modest increase in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 63rd percentile, with a PSF of \$207/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.44/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.01. This indicates that the city is slightly above average in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year suggests that Columbus may become more attractive to talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.44% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor supply. This decline in labor force growth poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Columbus has decreased by -20.69% year-over-year, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in building permits may lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for the city to accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Columbus is currently 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.7%. Although this suggests a relatively fast-paced market, the low percentile rank of 12th indicates that homes are still selling quickly, making it a competitive environment for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share that ranks it below average at the 32nd percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in knowledge-economy sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a mixed economic environment with a tight labor market and moderate wage growth, but also faces challenges such as a shrinking labor force and declining building permits. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering Columbus as a location is the potential for future affordability issues and hiring difficulties due to the limited labor supply and tightening housing market.

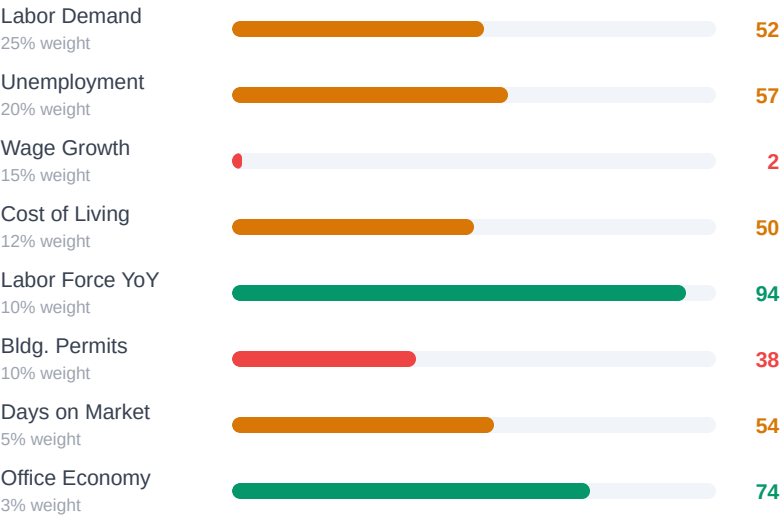
Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.8th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its stagnant wage growth, with a year-over-year change of -0.55%, and its strong labor force growth, with a 1.80% year-over-year increase. These two metrics signal a mixed economic environment, with a growing workforce but limited upward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is 0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.363% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand but also a slight contraction in hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 4.73 ranks near the median at the 52nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking near the median at the 57th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in Cleveland, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find workers, there is still some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's year-over-year wage growth rate is -0.55%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals limited upward pressure on labor costs for employers, but also weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

Cleveland has a cost of living score with a PSF of \$143/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$33.75/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.24, which ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to peers. The 13.5% year-over-year increase in PSF, however, may put upward pressure on housing costs. For talent attraction, this neutral affordability score means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of 1.80% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This expanding labor force supply signals a positive environment for hiring, with a growing pool of potential workers. Businesses can expect to find a increasing number of candidates for open positions.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cleveland is decreasing by 7.43% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This decline in permits signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could pose a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%. This ranks near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced housing market. For a worker relocating to Cleveland, this means that the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible.

Office Economy

Cleveland's office economy has a professional and office worker share of 3.28, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

Cleveland offers businesses a growing labor force and a relatively balanced labor market, but also poses risks due to stagnant wage growth and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential for decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, which could impact workforce accommodation and attraction.

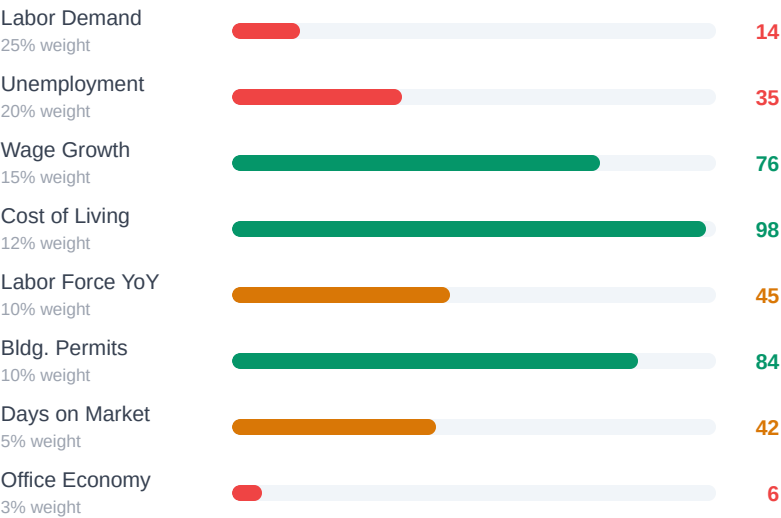
Memphis

Memphis

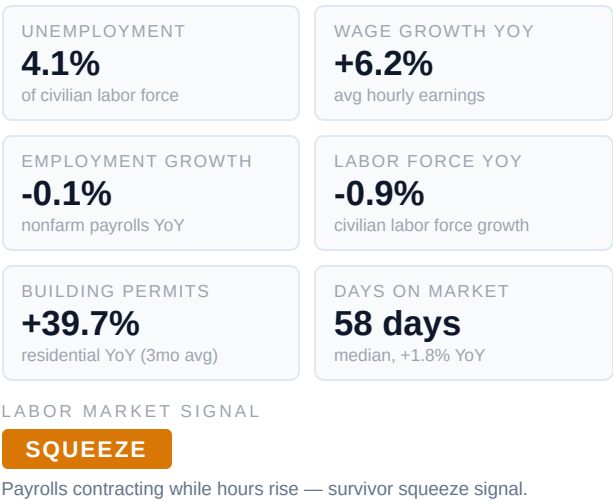
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.8th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year change of +6.18% ranking it in the 76th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.11% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.898% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 2.65, which ranks in the bottom tier. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend during job losses indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers to fill new positions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.10%, ranking it in the 35th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire workers, there is still some competition for talent, and businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract the best candidates. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also suggests that local consumer demand may be weaker than in other cities.

Wage Growth

Memphis has a year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.18%, ranking it in the 76th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer spending. However, this fast wage growth may also lead to increased labor costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a cost of living score ranking it in the 98th percentile, with a PSF of \$155/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.78. This high percentile rank indicates that Memphis is highly affordable relative to its peers, with a PSF that is falling by -6.1% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor for businesses, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is growing at a rate of -0.89% year-over-year, ranking it near the median. This contraction in labor force supply suggests that the hiring capacity of businesses may be limited, and they may face challenges in finding skilled workers to fill new positions. However, this trend may also lead to increased competition for workers among existing businesses.

Building Permits

Memphis has a year-over-year change in building permits of +39.70%, ranking it in the 84th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for workers to relocate to the city. This trend is positive for businesses that rely on a growing and diverse workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Memphis is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.8%. This moderate days on market suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible. However, the rising trend in days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the market, making it easier for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Memphis has an office economy score ranking it in the 6th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers of 0.58. This low percentile rank indicates that the city has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industries that require a stronger logistics or industrial presence.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses a unique combination of high affordability and fast wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies that can navigate its complex economic environment. However, the city's low labor demand and limited labor force growth pose significant risks and constraints for businesses, particularly those that require a deep talent pool or rapid hiring capacity. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering Memphis as a potential location for their business.

St. Louis

St. Louis

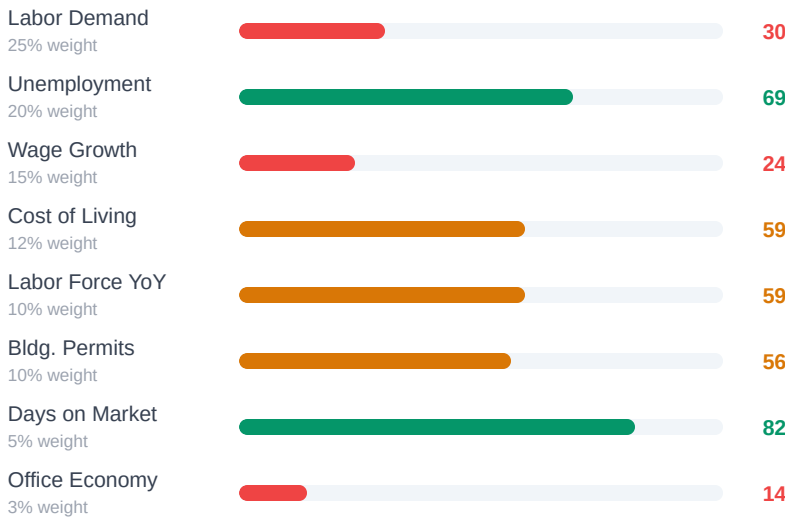
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.1th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.8%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+4.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
42 days
median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.63 ranking it in the 30th percentile, and its above-average unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks it in the 69th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a relatively slow job market and moderate labor availability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is -0.48% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the city's own 12-month baseline by -0.025%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative employment growth rate and below-trend hours suggest that the job market is slowing down.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.60%, which is relatively low and ranks in the 69th percentile. This suggests a tight labor market with moderate slack, making it somewhat challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is +1.80%, which is below average and ranks in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. Workers in St. Louis will see some improvement in their purchasing power, but it may not be as strong as in other metros.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living score ranking it in the 59th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$166/sqft to \$37.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.42. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The stable year-over-year change in PSF (+0.0% YoY) indicates that affordability is not significantly improving or deteriorating. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as they may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.01% year-over-year, which is near the median and ranks in the 59th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is barely expanding, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the long term. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +4.06% year-over-year, which is near the median and ranks in the 56th percentile. This moderate growth in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the relatively slow pace of growth may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in St. Louis is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%. This ranks in the 82nd percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to St. Louis, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking it in the 14th percentile. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a slow but still accessible housing market, which can be attractive for businesses looking to relocate or expand. However, the city's below-average labor demand and slow labor force growth pose significant risks and constraints for businesses, particularly those that require a highly skilled workforce. Decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating St. Louis as a potential business location.

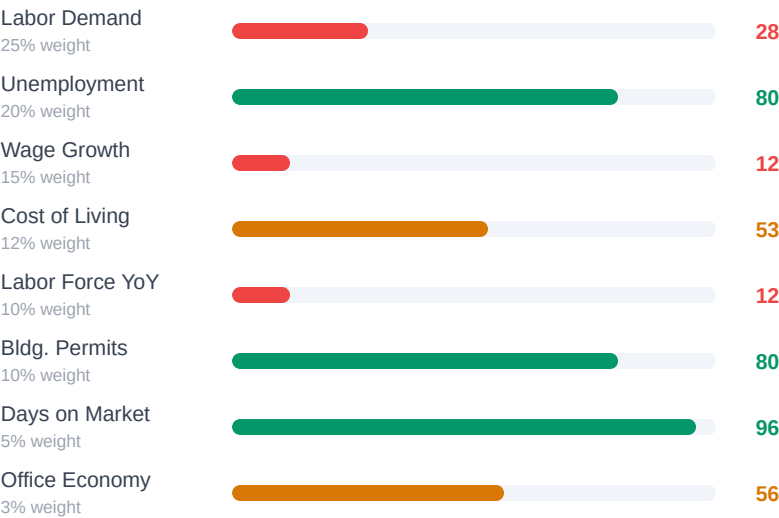
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

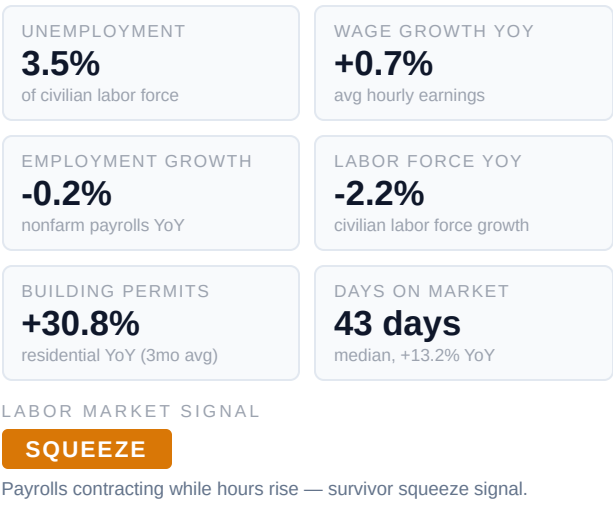
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.8th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the 28th percentile, and its high unemployment rate ranking, which is in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market. Specifically, the employment growth rate of -0.24% and weekly hours deviation of +0.467% suggest a complex labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.24%, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.467%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.50 is in the 28th percentile, indicating a below-average labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.50%, which ranks in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the market has little slack, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.74%, which is in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in worker purchasing power. The slow wage growth may make it harder for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score in the 53rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$290/sqft to \$42.65/hr, or 6.80. The fact that the PSF is falling by -3.3% YoY is a key driver of the city's near-median affordability score. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.22% year-over-year, which is in the 12th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent in this shrinking labor market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is increasing by +30.79% year-over-year, which is in the 80th percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, as more housing units become available to meet demand. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to attract and retain talent in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.2%, which is in the 96th percentile. This means that the housing market is slowing down, with homes taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, this slower market may make it easier to find a home, as there is less competition and more time to make a decision.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 2.80, which is in the 56th percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as well-suited for businesses that require a large pool of industrial or logistics workers.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a tight labor market with low unemployment, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent. Overall, the city's economic character is complex, with both positive and negative factors that businesses should carefully consider when making location decisions.

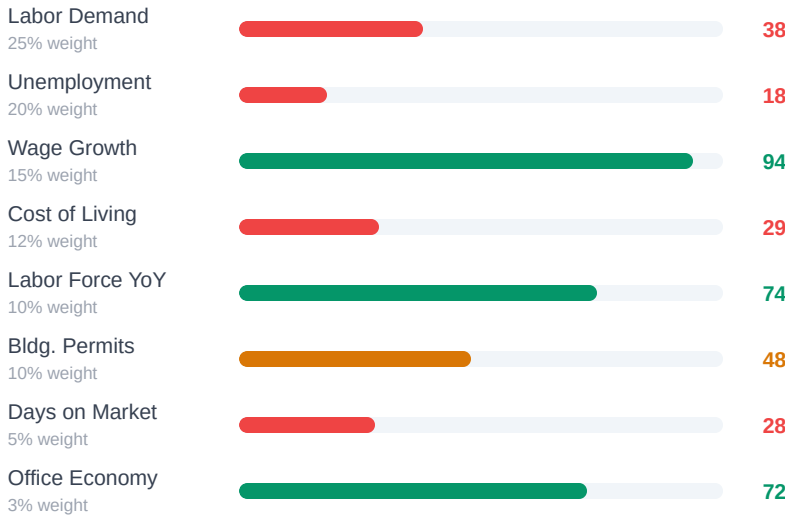
Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.4th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.30% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 3.90%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests that while the city has strong wage growth, its labor market is highly competitive.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.25% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.166% above the city's own trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding available labor to meet growing demands.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This signals a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may need to offer higher wages or more competitive benefits to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.30%, ranking it in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also strong purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a highly productive and consumptive workforce.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking it at the 29th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$358/sqft to \$34.04/hr, or 10.52. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling -1.4% year-over-year is a positive sign, but overall, the city's high cost of living may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of 0.35% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 74th percentile. This expanding labor force supply suggests that businesses may have an easier time finding available labor to meet growing demands. However, the slow growth rate may not be enough to keep up with demand in a tight labor market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is falling -0.50% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is not expanding quickly enough to meet demand, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tight housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 79 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This suggests a slowing market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, this may be a more accessible market, with more time to find and purchase a home. However, the relatively slow market may also signal weakening demand.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking it above average at the 72nd percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a highly skilled and knowledgeable workforce. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a highly productive and consumptive workforce, with strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool. However, the city's tight labor market, high cost of living, and slow housing supply growth pose significant challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating this location.

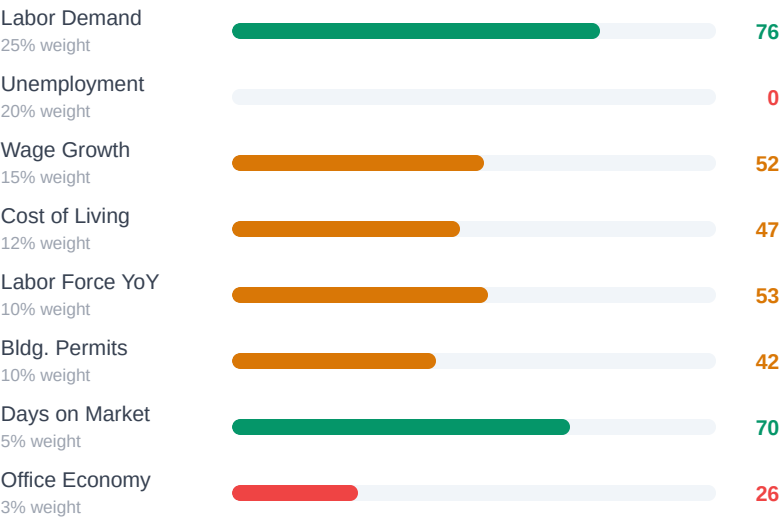
Fresno

Fresno

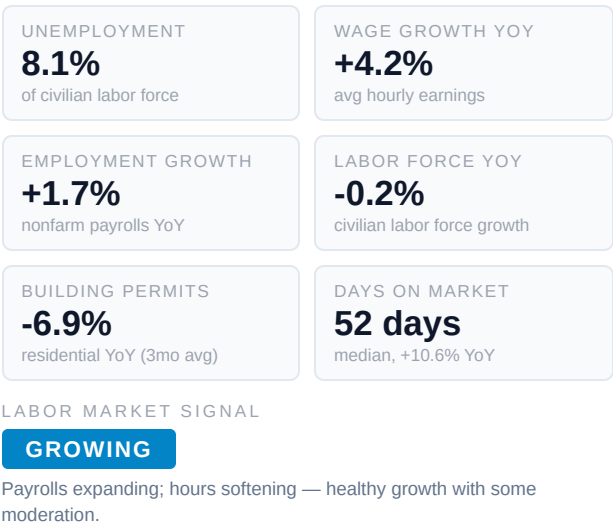
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.2th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand, with a composite score in the 76th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which stands at 8.10%. These two metrics suggest a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.67% year-over-year, and its weekly hours are deviating from trend by -0.768%, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.87. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend. However, the negative deviation in weekly hours may indicate some inefficiencies in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 8.10%, ranking it in the bottom tier with a 0th percentile score. This indicates a slack labor market with significant room for hiring. For a business trying to hire in Fresno, this means that there is a large pool of available workers, which could lead to easier staffing but also weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

Fresno's year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.17%, ranking it near the median with a 52nd percentile score. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in Fresno are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which could have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score ranking it in the 47th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$261/sqft to \$33.53/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.78. The city's PSF is also falling by 0.8% year-over-year. This makes Fresno relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is growing at a rate of -0.20% year-over-year, ranking it near the median with a 53rd percentile score. This negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, which could lead to structural headwinds for hiring in the future.

Building Permits

Fresno's residential building permits are decreasing by 6.89% year-over-year, ranking it near the median with a 42nd percentile score. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in

accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.6%, ranking it in the 70th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to Fresno, this could make the city's housing market more accessible, but it may also signal a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

Fresno's office economy is ranked in the 26th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 1.74. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting companies.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a unique combination of a high labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses that can navigate its challenges. However, the city's high unemployment rate and tightening housing supply are significant risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Fresno as a potential business location.

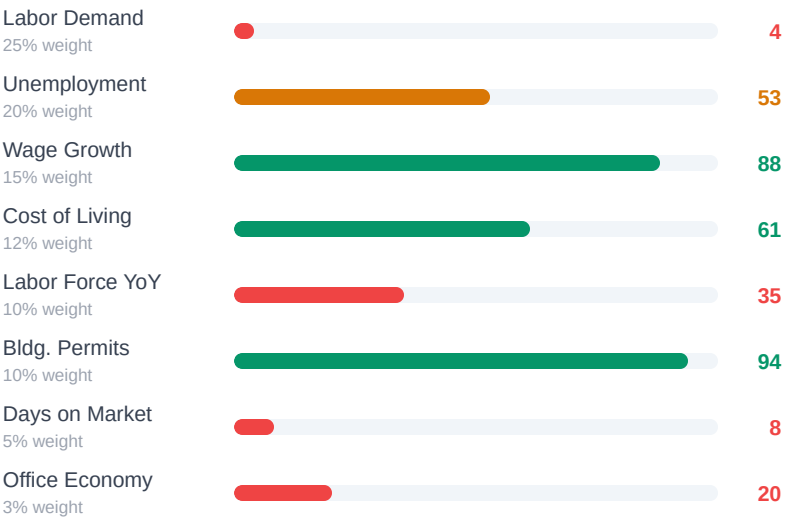
Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

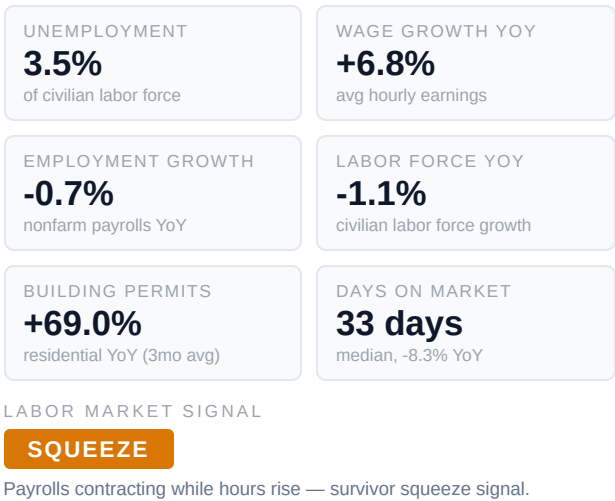
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.0th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year change of +6.78% ranking it in the top tier. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.73% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +2.049%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 1.78 is in the bottom tier, indicating a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.50%, ranking it near the median at the 53rd percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced market with neither significant slack nor extreme tightness. For a business trying to hire in this area, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable but not extremely favorable hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is +6.78%, ranking it in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but strong purchasing power for workers. Businesses operating in this area should be prepared for increasing labor costs.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is relatively high, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.32, ranking it at the 61st percentile. This means the city is less affordable than many of its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is increasing by +1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is shrinking at a rate of -1.08% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 35th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the workers they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area is increasing by +69.04% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in this area is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -8.3%. This fast-paced market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicates a competitive environment for workers relocating to this city, potentially making it tougher for them to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in this metro area is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile. This suggests a less deep talent pool for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, making this city less suited for such industries.

In conclusion, the Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex mix of high wage growth and challenging labor demand, alongside an expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the shrinking labor force, which could significantly impede hiring capacity and growth plans.

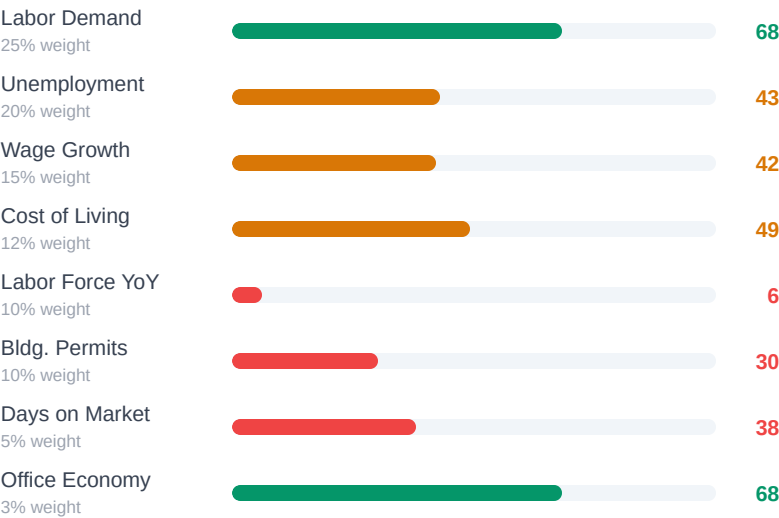
Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

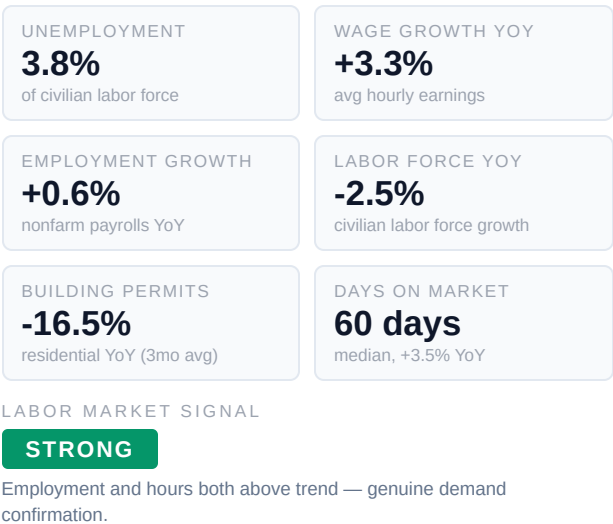
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.3th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.36, and its below-average labor force growth, which is contracting at a rate of -2.53% year-over-year. The labor demand is driven by employment growth of 0.62% and weekly hours 0.193% above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.62% and weekly hours deviation of 0.193% above trend signal genuine demand expansion in the Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to locate here. The labor demand composite score of 5.36 ranks in the 68th percentile, further supporting the notion of a strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.80%, which ranks in the 43rd percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This rate suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that businesses may face some competition for top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.26%, which ranks in the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing some increase in purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local businesses.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler, with a PSF of \$271/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.62, results in a ratio of 7.20, ranking in the 49th percentile. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.8% year-over-year further supports the city's affordability. This can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as workers may not require wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -2.53% year-over-year, which ranks in the 6th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which can be a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers, particularly in industries with high labor demands.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is -16.51%, which ranks in the 30th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend may negatively impact the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.5%. This ranks in the 38th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find a home, but it also suggests that the housing market is not as competitive as in other cities.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.14, ranking in the 68th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool in the professional and office sectors, making the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting industries. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with high logistics or industrial demands.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a deep talent pool in the professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses locating in this city is the shrinking labor force supply, which can make it challenging to find qualified workers and may limit the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

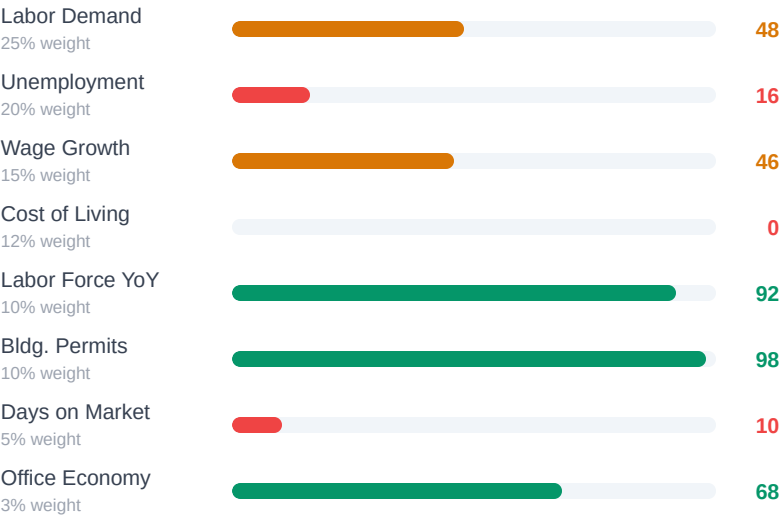
C+

POOR

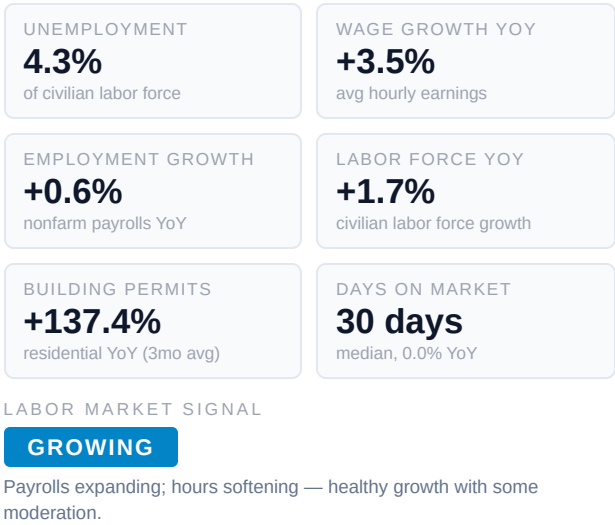
43.7th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.95, ranking it at the 0th percentile for affordability. The labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY is also a notable metric, indicating an expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.502% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.64, ranking near the median at 48th percentile. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand but not excessively strong. The hours deviation below trend suggests some inefficiency in labor utilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking at the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face moderate competition for talent, with some wage pressure. However, the market is not extremely tight, allowing for some flexibility in hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +3.51%, ranking near the median at 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. This balance may attract businesses looking for a stable labor market.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living percentile rank of 0, indicating that it is one of the most expensive cities relative to peers, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.95 and a PSF increase of +9.0% YoY. This means that the city is at a significant disadvantage for talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% YoY, ranking at the 92nd percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This implies that businesses have a growing pool of potential employees to hire from, making it easier to find talent and scale operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +137.37% YoY, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a rapid expansion of housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 30 days, with a YoY change of +0.0%, ranking at the 10th percentile. This indicates a highly competitive market, where homes sell quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 68, indicating a deeper professional talent pool than average, with a share of 3.14 out of 5. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, but the high cost of living and competitive housing market pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living, which may impact business profitability and competitiveness.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

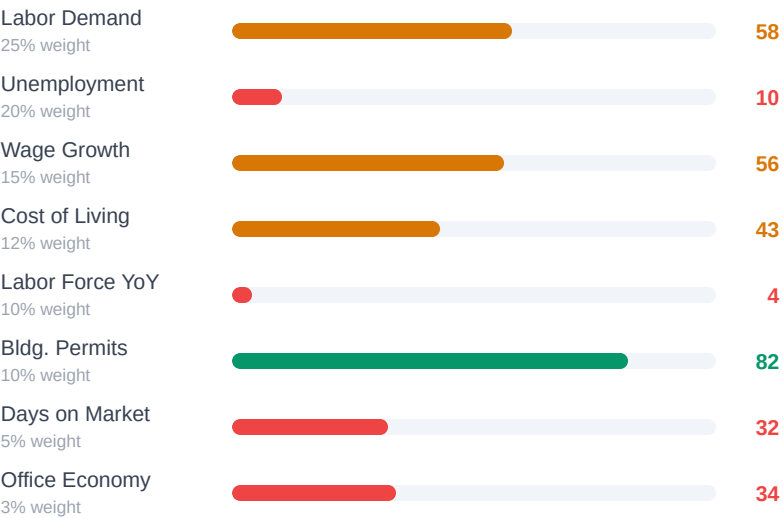
C+

POOR

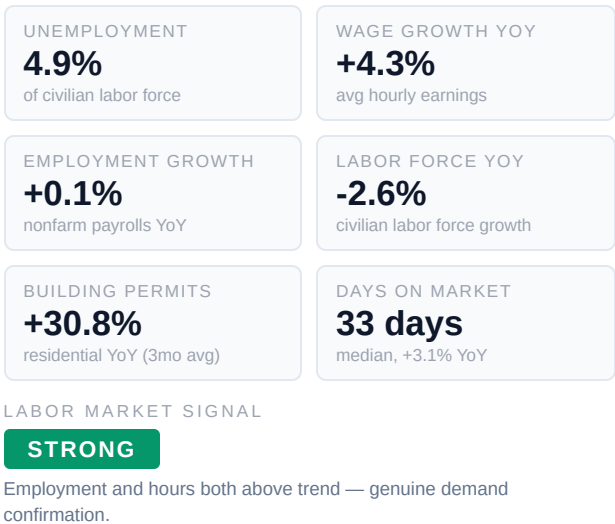
41.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 41.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.90% and its labor force growth rate of -2.60% YoY, indicating a tight labor market with a shrinking workforce. The combination of these metrics suggests that while there is demand for labor, the supply is constrained.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.08% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.475% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.89, which ranks near the median at the 58th percentile. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one. The city is adding jobs, and hours are running above trend, indicating that the existing workforce is being utilized more intensively.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.90%, which ranks at the 10th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that there is little slack in the labor market, making it challenging for businesses to hire new workers. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +4.27%, which ranks near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in their purchasing power, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score that ranks at the 43rd percentile, with a PSF of \$220/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$37.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.93. This indicates that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive relative to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising +1.4% YoY relative to wages means that affordability is not improving. As a result, businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent from other areas.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is shrinking at a rate of -2.60% YoY, which ranks at the 4th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply implies that hiring capacity will be constrained, making it challenging for businesses to find the workers they need. This structural headwind may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is increasing by +30.83% YoY, which ranks at the 82nd percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in developer confidence, which may lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is currently 33 days, with a YoY increase of +3.1%, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This indicates that the housing market is relatively slow, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising DOM may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin ranks at the 34th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is better suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, rather than tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a relatively stable labor market with moderate wage growth, but its tight labor market and shrinking workforce pose significant challenges for hiring and expansion. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited supply of labor, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums or invest in workforce development programs to attract and retain the talent they need.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

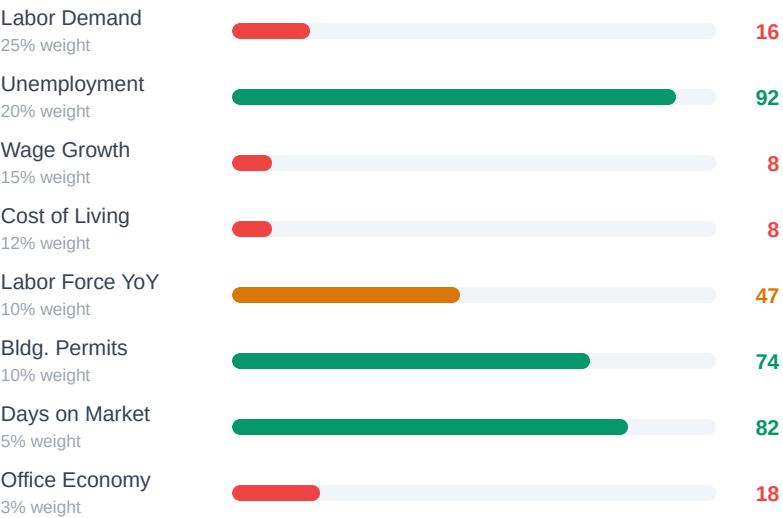
C+

POOR

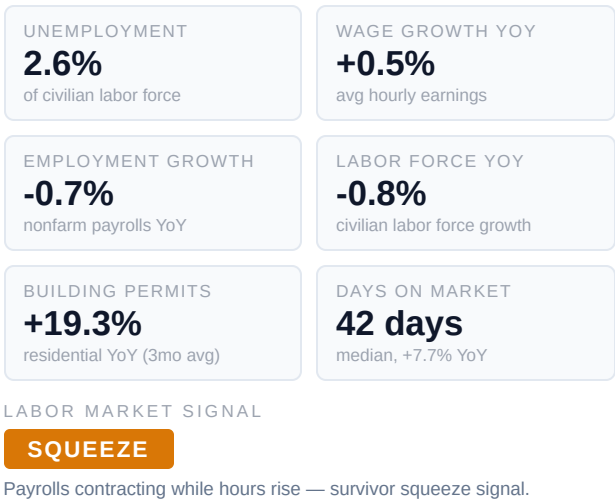
41.3th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 41.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 2.60% ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. The combination of these metrics, particularly the low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, signals a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.72% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.621%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This metric suggests that the city's labor market is not experiencing strong growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 2.60%, which is extremely low and ranks in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.46%, which is relatively stagnant and ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers have limited bargaining power and purchasing power is not increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$168/sqft to \$32.75/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.13. The city's cost of living is relatively expensive, particularly since the price per square foot is increasing by 5.0% year-over-year. This makes it less attractive for talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is shrinking at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 47th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity may be limited, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit new employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is increasing by 19.26% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks at the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city's affordability and workforce accommodation may improve in the future, as more housing options become available.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is currently 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home and negotiate prices.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in knowledge-economy sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting, but potentially more suitable for industries with different skill requirements.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers a unique combination of a tight labor market and relatively expensive cost of living, which may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and retain talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which may limit the city's appeal for businesses seeking to expand or relocate, particularly those in knowledge-economy sectors.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C+

POOR

39.4th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		18
25% weight		
Unemployment		45
20% weight		
Wage Growth		22
15% weight		
Cost of Living		88
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		67
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		20
10% weight		
Days on Market		34
5% weight		
Office Economy		54
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.8%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +1.6%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.0%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +0.1%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -19.1%	DAYS ON MARKET median, -1.7% YoY 57 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high affordability, with a cost of living percentile rank of 88th. The labor demand is characterized by a weak employment growth rate of +0.04% and a negative deviation in weekly hours of -1.862%.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.04% and weekly hours deviation of -1.862% signal a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the labor market is not strong, with fewer jobs being added and hours worked below trend. The low labor demand composite score of 2.86 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.80% indicates a near-median labor market with some slack, ranking at the 45th percentile. This means that while it is not extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that there may be a decent pool of candidates available, but wages may not be under significant pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.63% is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power may also be limited. The moderate wage growth rate implies that businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but may also not see a substantial boost in consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 88th, San Antonio-New Braunfels is relatively affordable, particularly given the PSF of \$173/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$31.85/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.43. The fact that PSF is falling by -5.0% YoY further enhances affordability. This makes the city attractive for talent attraction without requiring significant wage premiums, as the low cost of living can help offset moderate wages.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.11% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity in the city is not severely constrained, with a growing pool of potential workers. However, the growth rate is relatively slow, ranking at the 67th percentile, which may not be sufficient to meet rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -19.15%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The low ranking of 20th percentile further reinforces this concern, implying that the city may face challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year decline of -1.7%. This relatively fast market suggests that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The below-average ranking of 34th percentile indicates that the market is competitive, with homes selling faster than in many other cities.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 54th, San Antonio-New Braunfels has a moderately deep professional talent pool. This makes the city suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers, but may not be ideal for those requiring a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool. The city's economy is likely to support a range of industries, but may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that require a highly concentrated professional workforce.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slowly expanding workforce supply, but the low labor demand and tightening housing supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the potential for labor market constraints and affordability challenges in the future, which could limit the city's attractiveness for businesses requiring rapid expansion or highly specialized talent.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C+

POOR

39.1th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		26
Unemployment 20% weight		12
Wage Growth 15% weight		64
Cost of Living 12% weight		78
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		59
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		8
Days on Market 5% weight		78
Office Economy 3% weight		22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.3%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +4.9%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.7%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +0.0%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -24.6%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +10.0% YoY 33 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the 26th percentile, and its high wage growth, at 4.92% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.74% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.249% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for workers, but also a less dynamic labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.30%, ranking it in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment. This means that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.92%, ranking it in the 64th percentile, indicating relatively fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but workers also have increasing purchasing power. Businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but also benefit from a more affluent local workforce.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score in the 78th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$221/sqft to \$36.90/hr, and a -1.3% year-over-year change in PSF. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of 0.01% year-over-year, ranking it near the median. This slow growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is barely expanding, which may pose a challenge for businesses looking to hire new workers. However, this also suggests that the labor market is relatively stable.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has decreased by 24.64% year-over-year, ranking it in the 8th percentile. This sharp decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. This may impact businesses that rely on a mobile workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 33 days, with a 10.0% year-over-year increase, ranking it in the 78th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which can be an advantage for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy score ranking it in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with more industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of relatively low labor demand and high wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and retain workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this area is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and impact workforce attraction and retention.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

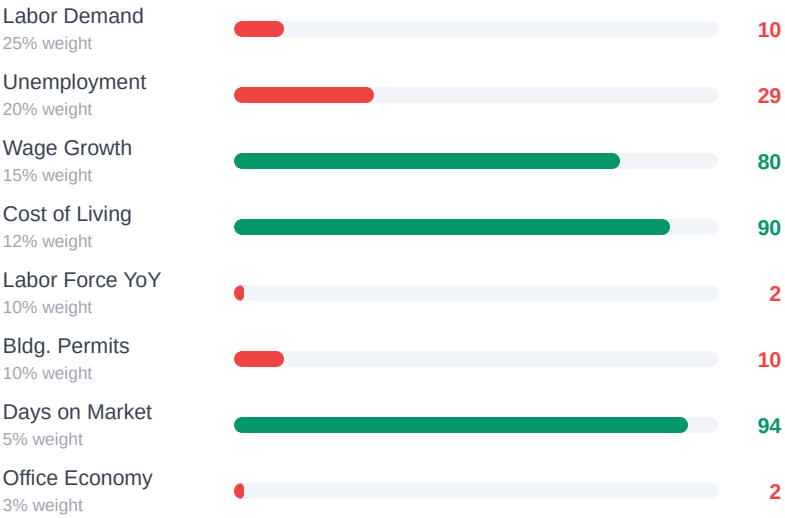
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VERY POOR

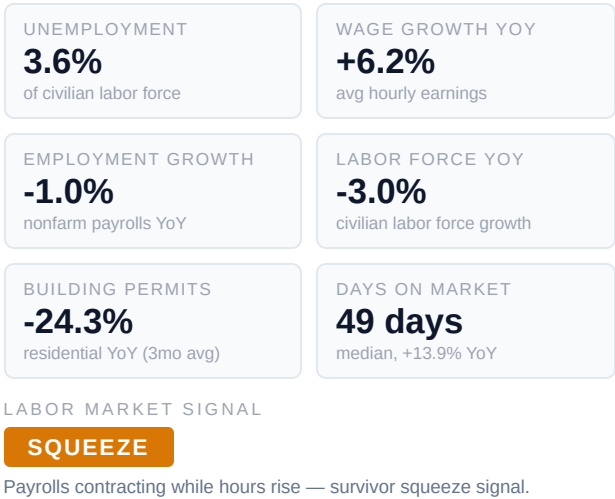
37.0th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C, ranking 37th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its low labor demand and high wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 2.28, combining a -0.96% employment growth rate and a +0.677% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand. Additionally, the 6.23% year-over-year wage growth rate is a notable aspect of the city's economic character.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.96%, and weekly hours are deviating +0.677% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation, which may lead to a surplus of labor. The labor demand composite score of 2.28 falls in the bottom tier, at the 10th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.60%, which is below average, ranking at the 29th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Oklahoma City is experiencing a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.23%, which is relatively fast, ranking at the 80th percentile. This rapid wage growth may lead to increased labor costs for employers, but it also contributes to stronger worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for rising labor costs when considering relocation to this city.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$173/sqft to \$33.90/hr, Oklahoma City is relatively affordable, ranking at the 90th percentile. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.6% year-over-year relative to wages further supports this affordability. This makes the city an attractive location for talent, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -3.01% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in labor supply. This decline in the labor force may create a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Oklahoma City has decreased by -24.28% year-over-year, signaling a tightening of housing supply. This decline in building permits may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Oklahoma City are currently sitting on the market for 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.9%. This slower pace of home sales, ranking at the 94th percentile, may indicate a more accessible market for relocating workers, giving them more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking at the 2nd percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a unique combination of relatively low labor demand and high wage growth, making it an attractive location for businesses that can adapt to these conditions. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which may create challenges in finding and retaining talent.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C

VERY POOR

36.7th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		36
25% weight		
Unemployment		20
20% weight		
Wage Growth		48
15% weight		
Cost of Living		24
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		98
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		18
10% weight		
Days on Market		2
5% weight		
Office Economy		60
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.4% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +2.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -20.6% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 25 days median, -3.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.73. This city's current economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand and extremely low days on market, with homes selling very quickly at a median of 25 days, down 3.9% year-over-year. The combination of -0.41% employment growth and -0.399% weekly hours deviation signals a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.41% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.399% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a pace that would suggest genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be experiencing a period of payroll contraction.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, which is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, but not excessively so, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also implies that there may be some wage pressure, as workers have more bargaining power in a tighter labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.66%, which is near the median, ranking in the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the wage growth is not strong enough to suggest a highly competitive labor market.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score that ranks in the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$497/sqft, which is decreasing by 1.6% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of \$46.24/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.75. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The decreasing PSF is a positive sign, but the overall cost of living remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +2.87% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 98th percentile. This suggests that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, making it easier for businesses to hire and find talent. The strong labor force growth is a significant advantage for companies looking to locate in the area.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is decreasing by -20.56% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking in the 18th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decline in building permits is a significant risk factor for businesses considering location in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 25 days, which is decreasing by 3.9% year-over-year. This suggests that the housing market is highly competitive, making it challenging for relocating workers to find homes. The fast-paced market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 60th percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a highly educated and growing workforce, with a strong labor force growth rate and a deep professional talent pool. However, the city's extremely low days on market and tightening housing supply pose significant risks to affordability and workforce accommodation, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in these constraints when considering location in the area.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

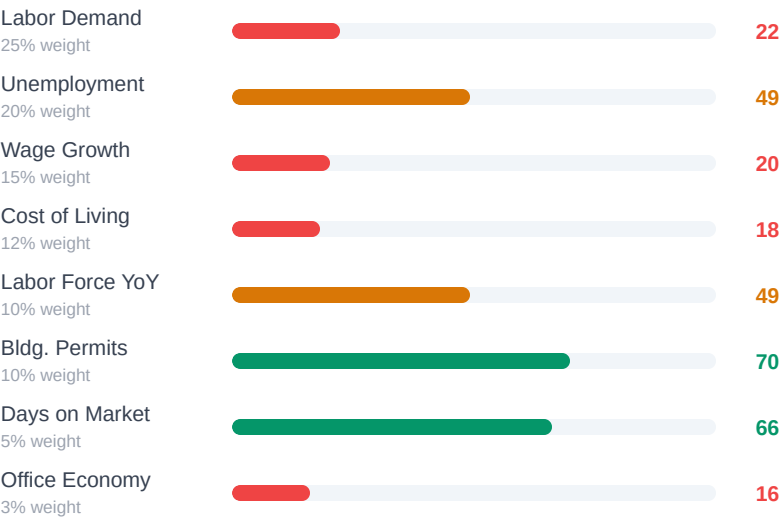
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VERY POOR

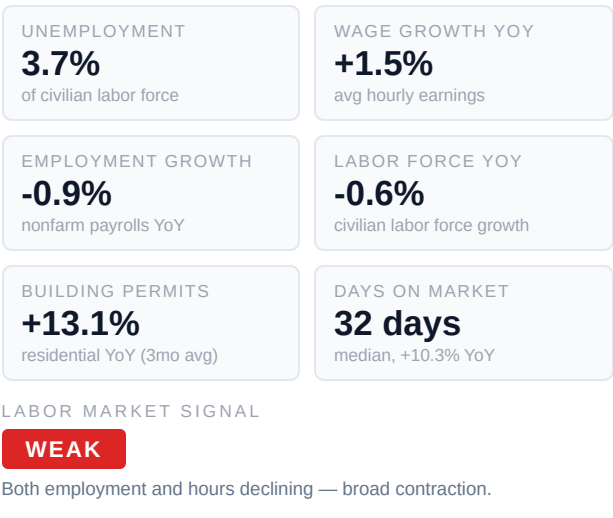
36.2th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its below-average labor demand and high cost of living. The labor demand composite score of 3.03, combining a -0.91% employment growth rate and a -0.049% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. Additionally, the cost of living, with a PSF of \$227/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.29, ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.91% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.049% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a genuine demand contraction, rather than a survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 3.03 is below average, ranking in the 22nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.70%, ranking in the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that there may be some upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.49%, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. Worker purchasing power is also increasing, but at a slower rate than in other metros.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Milwaukee-Waukesha, with a PSF of \$227/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.29, ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive market. This means that the city is less competitive in terms of talent attraction, as workers may require wage premiums to afford the cost of living. The city's affordability score is low, making it challenging to attract talent without offering higher salaries.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of -0.58% year-over-year, ranking in the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median level of labor force growth. However, the negative growth rate suggests that the labor force is actually contracting, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring. This contraction may limit the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +13.09% year-over-year, ranking in the 70th percentile, indicating an above-average expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is strong, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which may improve affordability and support workforce growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 32 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.3%, ranking in the 66th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha ranks in the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers a relatively slow-paced labor market with moderate wage growth, but its high cost of living and contracting labor force pose significant challenges for businesses. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's limited labor force growth, which may hinder business expansion and require wage premiums to attract talent. Overall, the city's economic character is defined by its below-average labor demand and high cost of living, making it a less competitive location for businesses seeking to attract and retain top talent.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C

VERY POOR

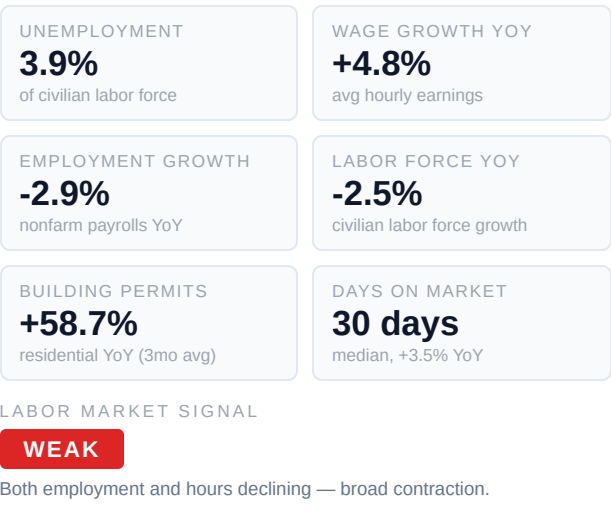
35.7th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its struggling labor demand and high cost of living. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.86% employment growth rate and a -0.505% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand. This is further exacerbated by a labor force growth rate of -2.52%, indicating a shrinking workforce.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -2.86% and weekly hours deviation of -0.505% indicate a contraction in labor demand, signaling that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This combination suggests that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 is in the bottom tier, ranking 0th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.90% is below average, ranking 33rd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face moderate competition for talent, but still have a manageable pool of candidates to choose from. However, the relatively low unemployment rate may also lead to some wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.85% is above average, ranking 62nd percentile, indicating relatively fast wage growth. This signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$310/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.93, is relatively affordable, ranking 69th percentile. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.1% YoY relative to wages means that the city is becoming more affordable over time. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can afford a higher quality of life without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -2.52% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +58.73%, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This signals that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city is likely to become more attractive to workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 30 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.5%. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking 18th percentile, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising DOM may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 1.98, ranking 34th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a unique combination of relatively fast wage growth and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses that can adapt to a shrinking labor pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's struggling labor demand, which may limit the availability of talent and require businesses to invest in recruitment and training programs.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C

VERY POOR

35.6th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		20
25% weight		
Unemployment		22
20% weight		
Wage Growth		30
15% weight		
Cost of Living		51
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		55
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		40
10% weight		
Days on Market		90
5% weight		
Office Economy		48
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.4% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.3% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.9% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -7.4% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 38 days median, +8.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its below-average labor demand and moderate cost of living. The labor demand composite score of 3.00, combining a -0.93% employment growth rate and a -0.632% weekly hours deviation from trend, suggests a contraction in job market activity. The cost of living, with a PSF of \$183/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.15, results in a ratio of 4.93, placing it near the median in terms of affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.93% and weekly hours deviation of -0.632% from the city's own trend indicate a contraction in labor demand, signaling that the job market is not expanding. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a genuine demand contraction, rather than a survivor squeeze. The below-average labor demand composite score of 3.00 reinforces this assessment, ranking in the 20th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% is slightly below the national average, but still indicates some slack in the labor market, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some availability of labor. However, the relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros may lead to weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.32% is moderate, indicating that labor costs are rising, but not extremely rapidly. This rate, ranking in the 30th percentile, suggests that worker purchasing power is increasing, but at a slower pace than in many other metros. Employers can expect to see some upward pressure on wages, but it is not excessively high.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 51st, the city is near the median in terms of affordability, making it neither extremely attractive nor deterrent for talent. The PSF of \$183/sqft, combined with average hourly earnings of \$37.15, results in a ratio of 4.93, indicating that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -0.07%, indicating a very slight contraction in the labor pool. This near-median growth rate, ranking in the 55th percentile, suggests that the workforce supply is not expanding rapidly, which may pose a structural

headwind for hiring in the future.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -7.41%, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. Although this change ranks in the 40th percentile, which is near the median, it still signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk due to a potential supply squeeze.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.6%, placing it in the top tier with a 90th percentile rank. This suggests a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 2.54, ranking in the 48th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require an extremely specialized or large professional workforce, such as industrial or logistics companies, but may not be ideal for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely heavily on a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate wage growth environment, which can be attractive for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the below-average labor demand and slight contraction in the labor force, which may pose challenges for hiring and workforce expansion in the future.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

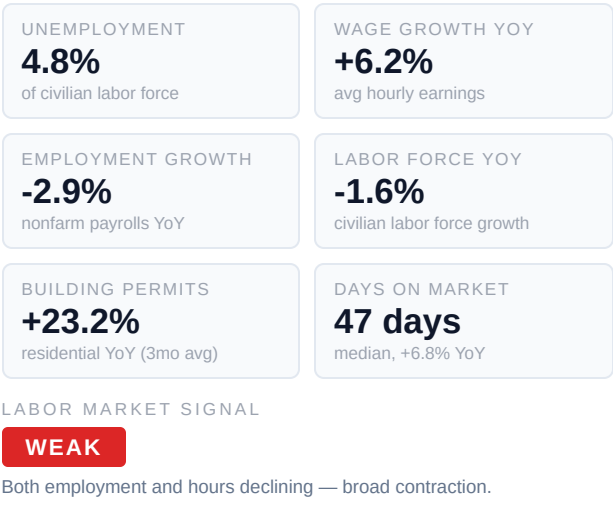
35.4th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and low office economy share. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.85% employment growth rate and a -0.220% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand. Additionally, the low office economy share of 0.68, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, highlights the city's limited professional talent pool.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -2.85% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.220% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in both job creation and working hours. As a result, businesses may face a less competitive environment for talent, but also fewer pressures to rapidly expand their workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.80%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively slack labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, as there is a larger pool of available talent, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. However, the relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros may limit wage pressure, making it a more attractive location for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is +6.21%, ranking above average at the 78th percentile, indicating relatively fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on a strong local consumer base. However, rapid wage growth may also lead to increased labor costs for businesses, potentially affecting their bottom line.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score ranking above average at the 65th percentile, with a PSF of \$310/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.24/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.34. The city's cost of living is relatively affordable, with the PSF falling -2.5% year-over-year, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This can be a major advantage for businesses looking to attract and retain workers without breaking the bank.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is contracting at a rate of -1.57% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction in labor supply may create structural headwinds for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need to expand or maintain their operations. As a result, businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by +23.17% year-over-year, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in building permits signals that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which can improve affordability and make the city more attractive to relocating workers. However, the current pace of growth may not be sufficient to meet demand, and businesses should monitor the situation closely.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is currently 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.8%, indicating a slowing market. This means that workers relocating to the city may find a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to attract talent. However, the slowing market may also indicate weakening demand, which could have implications for local consumer spending and economic growth.

Office Economy

The office economy in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is relatively underdeveloped, with a professional and office worker share of 0.68, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This indicates a limited talent pool for businesses that require specialized office or professional workers, making the city less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics sectors, which can capitalize on the available workforce and relatively affordable cost of living.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slowing housing market, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. However, the city's weak labor demand, contracting labor force, and limited office economy share pose significant risks and constraints for businesses, particularly those that rely on a strong professional talent pool. As a result, decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering the city as a potential location for their business.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

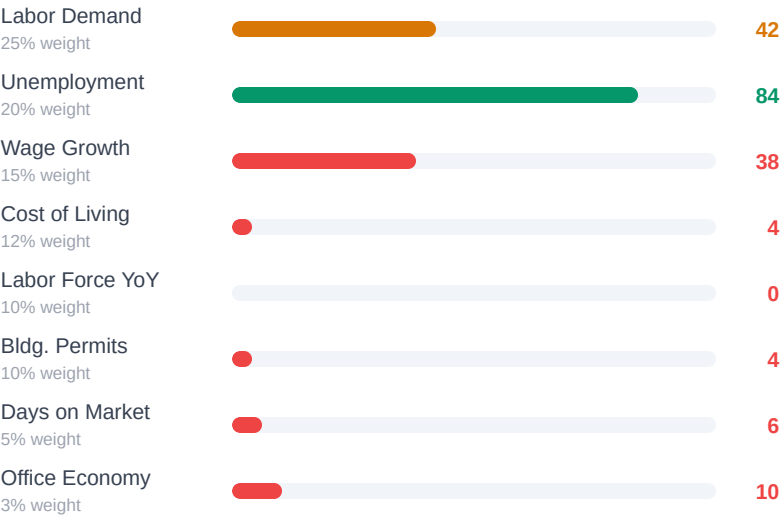
C

VERY POOR

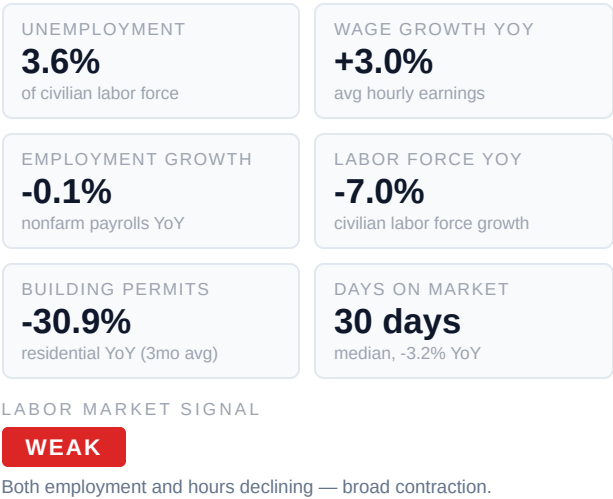
34.4th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.16. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.60% and its struggling labor force growth, which has contracted by -6.97% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics signals a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.10% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.605%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative employment growth rate and below-trend hours suggest that businesses may not be adding new jobs at a significant pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 3.60%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring new employees, as the pool of available workers is limited. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.97%, which is below average. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming pace. However, workers in this city may not have significant bargaining power, as wage growth is not exceptionally strong.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living percentile rank of 4th, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The city's PSF is \$224/sqft, with an 8.7% year-over-year increase, and the ratio of PSF to hourly earnings is 6.88. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may be a deterrent for some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has contracted by -6.97% year-over-year, indicating that the workforce supply is shrinking. This contraction suggests that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring and expanding their operations in the city, as the available labor pool is decreasing.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -30.86%, indicating that housing supply is tightening. This decline in building permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the city's housing stock is not expanding to meet demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 30 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.2%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the city's housing market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges in finding available homes.

Office Economy

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has an office economy percentile rank of 10th, indicating that the professional talent pool is relatively shallow. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and may not be ideal for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively low unemployment rate and a moderate wage growth environment, but it is constrained by a shrinking labor force and a tightening housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor pool and high cost of living, which may make it challenging to attract and retain top talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

C

VERY POOR

34.1th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		54
25% weight		
Unemployment		35
20% weight		
Wage Growth		14
15% weight		
Cost of Living		14
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		16
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		32
10% weight		
Days on Market		86
5% weight		
Office Economy		24
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.5%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.4%	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -13.7%	DAYS ON MARKET 41 days median, +7.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low wage growth and high cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by its stagnant wage growth of +1.14% YoY and a cost of living ratio of 9.01, with \$344/sqft versus \$38.20/hr. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.44% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.101% below trend, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score of 4.81. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked not increasing significantly, suggesting some genuine demand but not a strong surge. The labor market is not experiencing a significant contraction or survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.50%, ranking below average at the 35th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the market is not so loose that it would lead to significantly weaker consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.14%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals a flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may have limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living ratio of 9.01, with \$344/sqft versus \$38.20/hr, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The lack of affordability may deter some businesses from locating in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.68% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has decreased by -13.71% YoY, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially affecting the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 41 days, with a +7.9% YoY increase, ranking it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible and less competitive market for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, making the city less suited for these types of companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a moderate labor market with some challenges in attracting and retaining talent due to its high cost of living and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor pool, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to offer competitive wages to attract qualified workers.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

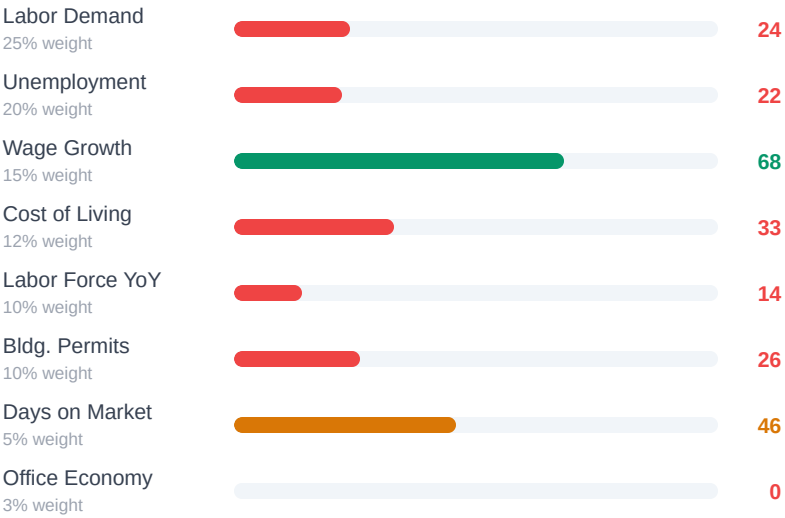
C-

CRITICAL

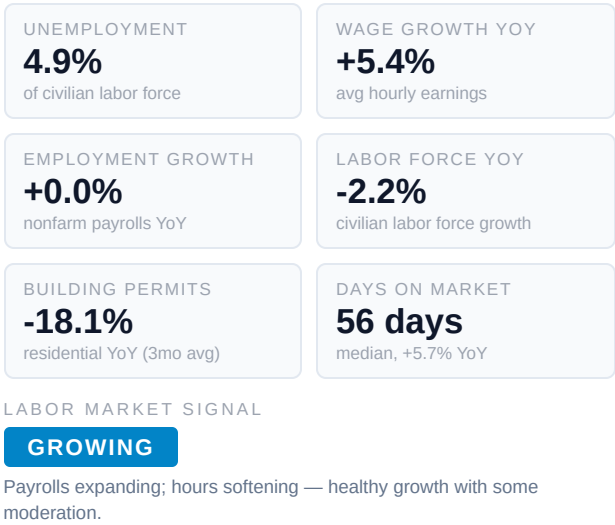
30.9th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.03, and its above-average wage growth of 5.40% year-over-year. The labor demand and wage growth metrics signal a complex economic environment, with slow job growth and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.01% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.281% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as hours are below trend despite minimal job growth, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers to fill new positions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 4.90%, ranking it 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. As a result, companies may need to consider the potential impact of a slower local economy on their sales and revenue.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.40%, ranking it 68th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, which may be a challenge for businesses with tight margins. However, it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit businesses that rely on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score of 9.57, with a price per square foot of \$337 and average hourly earnings of \$35.23, ranking it 33rd percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive, with a high price-to-earnings ratio, making it less attractive for talent attraction without wage premiums. Businesses may need to offer higher salaries to compensate for the high cost of living, which can increase their labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, ranking it 14th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is

shrinking. Companies may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is decreasing by 18.08% year-over-year, ranking it 26th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening of the housing supply, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, making it challenging for workers to relocate to the area. This trend may exacerbate the labor force contraction and limit the city's ability to attract new talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.7%, ranking it 46th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may face a moderately competitive housing market, with some flexibility in finding a new home.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a professional and office worker share of 0.16, ranking it 0th percentile, indicating a very shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not rely heavily on professional or office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a relatively loose labor market and fast wage growth, but it also poses significant challenges, including a contracting labor force, decreasing affordability, and a shallow professional talent pool. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining skilled workers, which may limit their growth and competitiveness in the long run.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

C-

CRITICAL

30.8th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		6
Unemployment 20% weight		65
Wage Growth 15% weight		32
Cost of Living 12% weight		37
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		26
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		24
Days on Market 5% weight		38
Office Economy 3% weight		4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.0%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +2.3%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.8%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -1.4%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -18.6%	DAYS ON MARKET median, 0.0% YoY 38 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 1.91 ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, and its below-average wage growth of 2.34% year-over-year, ranking at the 32nd percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.80% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +1.270%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. The positive deviation in weekly hours may suggest a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.00%, ranking at the 65th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is 2.34%, ranking at the 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. Workers in the area will see some improvement in their purchasing power, but it may not be as significant as in cities with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score ranking at the 37th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$180/sqft to \$31.28/hr, or 5.75. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The lack of affordability may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the cost of living is a significant consideration for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is contracting at a rate of -1.41% year-over-year, ranking at the 26th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by 18.58% year-over-year, ranking at the 24th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to increased competition for available housing and upward pressure on prices. This could exacerbate affordability concerns and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 38 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively slow pace of home sales indicates a buyer-friendly market, which may be beneficial for workers relocating to the area. However, the lack of change in days on market may also suggest that the housing market is not experiencing significant pressure, which could be a sign of a relatively stable but unremarkable market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.44, ranking at the 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making the city less suited for businesses that rely heavily on professional or office workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. The city may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively stable but unremarkable economic environment, with some challenges in labor demand, wage growth, and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining labor force supply, which may limit the city's ability to support business expansion or relocation. Businesses will need to carefully consider these factors when evaluating Louisville-Jefferson County as a potential location.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C-

CRITICAL

30.4th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)

Labor Demand		32
25% weight		
Unemployment		39
20% weight		
Wage Growth		10
15% weight		
Cost of Living		22
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		43
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		36
10% weight		
Days on Market		44
5% weight		
Office Economy		12
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.8%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +0.5%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.4%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -12.0%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +3.0% YoY 34 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.68, and its stagnant wage growth, at +0.51% year-over-year. The labor demand and wage growth metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.099% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are not increasing, suggesting a lack of genuine demand expansion. This could lead to a surplus of workers, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially indicating a weaker local economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 3.80%, which is below average, ranking 39th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests that the local consumer demand may be stronger due to a lower number of unemployed individuals.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.51%, which is stagnant and ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power, potentially limiting their purchasing power and overall economic well-being.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score that ranks 22nd percentile, with a PSF of \$214/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$39.19/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.46. The PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year, making the city more affordable relative to peers. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction benefit for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is growing at a rate of -0.90% year-over-year, which is near the median but still indicates a contracting labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is shrinking, making it potentially more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -11.97%, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of housing is not expanding to meet demand, potentially limiting the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.0%. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly, giving buyers some time to make decisions and find suitable housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington ranks in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a accessible housing market, but it also presents challenges such as low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited talent pool in professional and office sectors, which may hinder the growth and expansion of businesses that rely on these skills.

Richmond

Richmond

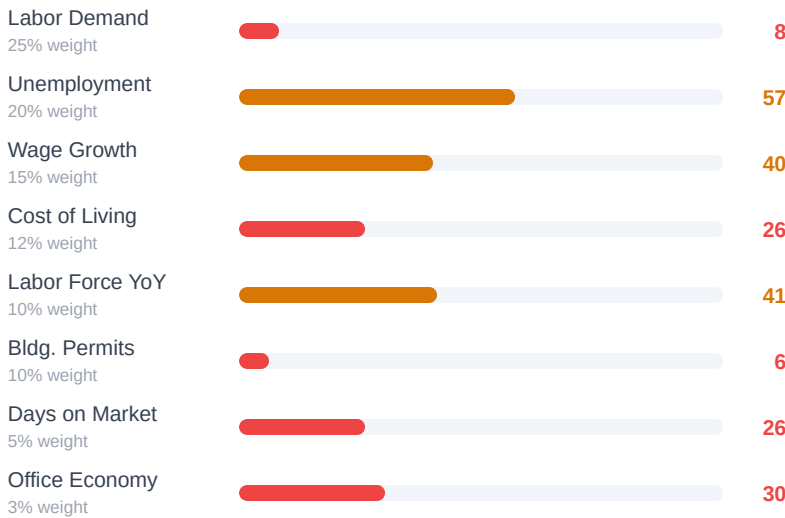
C-

CRITICAL

29.5th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.9%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-28.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

36 days
median, -2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 29.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its stagnant labor force growth. The labor demand composite score of 2.22, combining a -0.54% employment growth rate and a +1.323% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.54% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 1.323% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 2.22, ranking in the bottom tier, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.40%, ranking at the 57th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This means that while the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, and businesses may face some challenges in hiring. However, the moderate unemployment rate also suggests that there is a pool of available workers to draw from.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Richmond is +3.03% year-over-year, ranking at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage increases. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. The moderate wage growth rate may help attract and retain workers, but it also means that businesses need to factor in rising labor costs.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking at the 26th percentile, with a PSF of \$232/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.20/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.41. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 2.2% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -0.93% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the supply of workers. This decline in labor force growth suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring and expanding their workforce. The shrinking labor pool may lead to increased competition for available workers and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond has decreased by 28.08% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in building permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. The sharp decrease in permits may lead to increased housing costs and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.7%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. The competitive market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Richmond has an office economy score ranking at the 30th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, and more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Richmond metro area offers businesses a relatively competitive labor market and moderate wage growth, but it also poses significant challenges, including a low labor demand, stagnant labor force growth, and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in Richmond is the potential for increased labor costs and reduced affordability due to the shrinking labor pool and declining housing supply.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

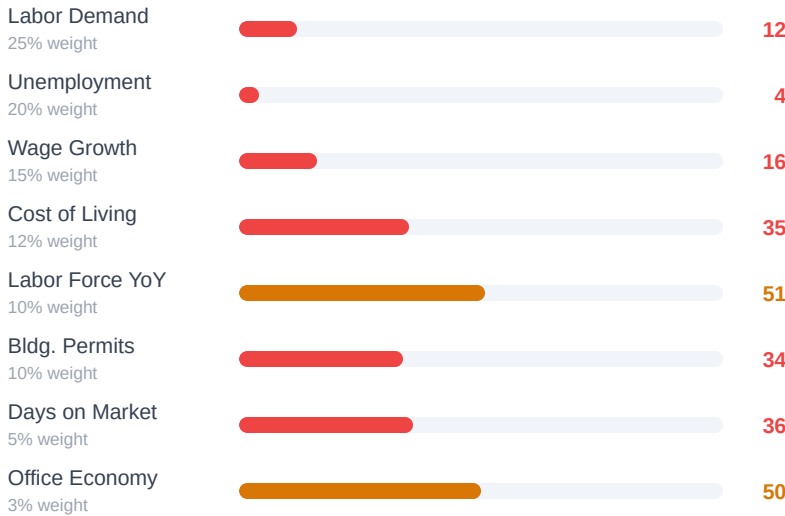
D

EMERGENCY

22.2th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.5%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-12.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

59 days

median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Jacksonville metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 22.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.55, which is in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This city's current economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand and high unemployment rate of 4.80%, indicating a challenging environment for businesses. The combination of a -0.42% employment growth rate and a +1.17% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Jacksonville is -0.42% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 1.17% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.55 is in the bottom tier, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, which is in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, but also have an opportunity to attract workers at lower wages. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Jacksonville is +1.23%, which is in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The slow wage growth may make it easier for businesses to manage labor costs, but it also limits the attractiveness of the city to workers.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score of 35th percentile, with a PSF of \$218/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.93. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.7% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming even more affordable, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is contracting at a rate of -0.49% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 51st percentile. This means that the workforce supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Jacksonville is falling by -12.00% year-over-year, which is below average at the 34th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. The decline in building permits may limit the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Jacksonville is 59 days, with a year-over-year decline of -1.7%, which is below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market, where homes are selling quickly. However, the decline in days on market may suggest a normalization of the market, making it more accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Jacksonville is 2.62, which is near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates a moderate depth of professional talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers. However, the city may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Jacksonville metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate depth of professional talent pool. However, the city's weak labor demand, high unemployment rate, and tightening housing supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor in when considering a location decision. The single biggest constraint for businesses in Jacksonville is the challenging labor market, which may limit their ability to attract and retain workers.